Parallels

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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by Jezmatron

Summary

Chapter 10 of SPACE CAPTAIN CATRA

Our two favourites are faced with choices, challenges and an ongoing look at their own tumultuous relationship.

Who will be caught in their wake as their cross-system rivalry simmers.

Adora looks to retake her lost ship; Catra looks to consolidate her hold on the system. The Rebels are down, but are they out? And what new threats may lurk in the darkness of space.

Chapter 1

The red running lights cast the crew compartment in bleak relief, like a charnel house or the sticky floored memory of her history. It was rather apt, Adora thought, as she floated in the zero-gravity, curled up in a ball, near motionless as she stared at the container that drifted a scant few feet from her.

It meant salvation, safety.

It meant strength and power.

It meant purpose.

It meant chains and memories.

It meant more blood.

Idly, her hand fumbled at the crude harness around her torso. She could feel the micro-static in her teeth; the slowing of an inevitable process. She knew there was only one *real* way to be truly free. And there were so many steps to get there. It felt hopeless, knowing the obstacles ahead.

Take the loss, Adora .

A humourless smile tugged at the corner of her mouth.

"If only you knew how true that was, Catra," she murmured.

To be free of the things eating her from the inside, she could either hope her current allies could find a solution (If they were still inclined to); or she could put on that *thing* again and be chained in another way. Relapse and run that risk of other challenges - the Weaver's protocols, the Horde's ever expanding technological terrors, or just a relapse into the abject power the *thing* gave her.

Or she could keep doing what she *had* been doing - dig into the strange powers of this system - the powers that had made Swiftwind. Not the shuttle, the core of the machine itself: the ethereal, eldritch generator at his core. That had given her succor, a relief from the creeping tendrils that the *thing* in the container always tried to exert.

But to do that, she'd need to pick one of the other two options. And one avenue would be a *lot* harder. She just wasn't sure which of the two was which.

The crackle of the comms panel in the cockpit made Adora flinch. She sighed and unfurled, then pushed off the wall of the troop compartment, headed for the darkened cockpit. She glanced out of the canopy as she pulled herself into the pilot's chair, noting the

cluster of other ships that hung in the shadow of a shattered piece of planet.

More than she'd feared, but far fewer than she'd hoped. Shuttles, a few freighters, some refueling tankers and a couple of Horde gunships - those last ones had been a surprise.

With a slow intake of breath Adora keyed the comm, "Valkyrie One, go ahead."

"Valkyrie one, this is Regency. Um, mom wants to talk," Glimmer's subdued voice came over the radio. Adora snorted.

"I'm allowed aboard now?" she tried to keep the bitterness from her voice. She heard Glimmer's sigh from the other end of the call.

"Adora, you know it's just… precautions. They've got Lonnie secured as well. And, well, it didn't exactly go to plan."

"And you told them about Catra."

"I didn't. I don't know what… that's all about. But it's just mom trying to sort all this out. And when you said you wanted some alone time…"

"Didn't realise that meant I'd get a couple of ships worth of guns trained on *my* ship."

" *Adora, you and I both know why that is. They trusted your plan and… it sort of worked. But there's a lot of tension right now. And some people are throwing stupid accusations around, so… better we show we're placating all sides."*

"Right. Well, I'll go speak with *Commander* Angella, then be on my way."

"Adora wa-" but Glimmer was cut off as Adora thumbed the radio to *off* . She drew in a breath, calming her beating pulse. The chest rig tingled as it ramped up the power, keeping the monsters in her blood at bay. Adora swallowed and nodded slowly.

She knew what she needed to do.

—----------

The command deck of the base was a complete disaster. The rebels had clearly tried to scuttle much of the equipment before departure, but had botched it, given the speed of the Horde invasion. Casualties were still being tallied, but her troops had come out of it pretty unscathed. They'd cornered and captured a small number of security personnel who hadn't managed to get to the escape ships, along with a number of civilians who were even now being processed. Of course, their presence aboard a *hostile* station would not do them many favours, but Cata was minded to

be lenient - secure fines, send a few out-of-system to penal stations, then have the rest retained aboard to continue staffing the various amenities.

And what amenities. The place had a *bar* , a functional hydroponics bay, hangars, cargo fit-to-bursting with abandoned material and a whole damn *concourse* . This didn't feel like a military base - it was a town.

As she took in the mess of the commander centre she heaved a sigh. Having another site to secure would be a pain, but this one seemed a much better staging area than even the planet. The fuel station they'd secured was too rickety and vulnerable, while this place was a real fortress. The civilians - *rebels* - had managed well, but they hadn't had a fleet, or enough ordinance to properly secure it. Honestly, if they'd tried they probably *could* have held out for longer. But then again, they had more non-combatants. And that was what Catra had counted on.

It was why she'd given them an escape avenue, after all. If she'd *really* cornered them, it'd have turned into a knock-down, drag out fight. And that would have meant corridor-to-corridor fights, traps, hand to hand. She was confident she would have won the day, but her list of casualties would have been a *lot* higher.

"Ma'am, transmission from the Destroyer Indomitable."

Catra smirked - she'd had the ship renamed and official requested the change be formalised in the Horde naval registry. The navy was so vast that names for each ship were nigh-impossible to

track, so most only had a unique ID code. The names tended to be acknowledged at sector level only. Unless it was an Royal Guard vessel. Then you *knew* the name.

"Go ahead, Ensign, put them through."

"Captain, Commander Scorpia here. Sitrep as requested. The fleet is moving into holding positions around the base. We've towed the Rapier and Sabre into polar positions on the station as requested. The remainder of the fleet is now performing patrol runs at the perimeter. Uhm, repairs are ongoing, estimate repair of the main battery in 72 hours."

"Very good, Commander. Have the Sabre and Rapier gutted, main engines removed. We're requisitioning them as defence platforms. Contact Ice Base 1, see about securing further supplies. The Rebels had the right plan. We need to place perimeter defences around the station, point defence guns, fighter screens… assign a command group to get it done. We need to move fleet command to this location."

"Yes ma'am. And, um, the rebels?"

"Is the tracker working?"

"It… was?" She could hear Scorpia wince. Catra ground her teeth. She let out a slow breath.

“What happened?”

“Positioning for the gunships had them enter the debris field of the main planetoid, but… we lost them. That does track with what Entrapta told us about the radiation field there and the anomalous scans.”

Catra bit back a curse. She’d anticipated the civilians would try to flee the system or head for one of the gas giants. The destroyed planet was a riskier endeavour - the place was a sensor nightmare, with routes being damn near impossible to manage, resulting in the need to fly by line-of-sight and to emerge from the field to get bearings. They’d gotten *very* lucky tracking Adora’s flightpath and that had been via a pair of Entrapta’s prototype drones. It wasn’t impossible, but it meant a slow search. She bit her lip and mused.

Of course, that was if they chased people *in* there. All they really needed to do was monitor the overall planetoid for signals when the rebels *emerged* . Not a foolproof plan and they’d have blind spots, but all it would take would be one exit or re-entry and they could start to map things out.

And really, she was in no rush now. She’d *won* .

Catra grinned, although it felt more like a rictus, “Alright Scorpia. Well done. Secure your duties and then come over. We need to plan out how we want our new HQ to look.”

"Aye aye ma'am. Oh and… we've, um, we've detained Lieutenant Rogelio."

That made Catra twitch. She closed her eyes and breathed through her nose. Her ear twitched and her tail flicked once, "Very good. Bring him with you."

Scorpia acknowledge and the comm went dead. Catra let out a low hiss, her minor amount of satisfaction now turned to ash. She glared down at the blank holographic display, before she booted it up just for something to do. A wireframe of the station flickered to life, then sputtered out. Catra snarled, then sighed before she straightened and glanced around the room. Horde technicians hauled in new equipment and swarmed over sparking or burned out terminals. Several guards milled about, checking lockers and other access points.

Catra rolled her shoulders as she turned towards the room's exit, another destination in mind.

The brig.

—----------

Angella sat at the head of a poor excuse for a conference table, chin resting on interlaced fingers. She stared down at the surface

of the "table" - really, just a cargo crate balanced atop a few others to create a facsimile of a centre-piece. They'd requisitioned a cargo bay in one of the freighters, seeing as none of the ships really had a wardroom or similar. A few other figures lounged or stood around the cramped bay, leaning against cargo netting - Juliet and Casta whispered to one side, while the bounty-hunter Huntara glowered at the room in general from another corner. Glimmer sat on the other side of the table, quiet, but Angella could feel the irritation radiating from her daughter. Glimmer's husband, Bow, was elsewhere, trying to keep their motley collection of ships in one piece after their humiliating withdrawal.

Captain Mermista was also present, but pretty much focused on her partner. The surprise arrival of a pair of Horde Gunships and a motley crew of pirates had raised the spirits somewhat, but for some reason it had made Mermista *angrier* , although she was practically draped over the mustachioed buccaneer.

"Well, I suppose we better call this to order," Angella huffed as she looked around, "Glimmer, is… Adora joining us?"

"Yeah, where is that disappointment?" drawled Mermista from the other side of the room. Glimmer glared at the woman and Sea Hawk looked decidedly uncomfortable.

Surprisingly it was Juliet who spoke up, "You know we'd all be dead without her plan."

"Please," drawled Mermista, "Where was this terrifying super weapon I thought she was supposed to be? I thought she was

supposed to make the Horde pay for every inch on that station. Instead she cuts and runs…"

"To save ME!" Glimmer shouted.

"Wow, what a win. One *Princess* , versus a whole station."

"Sweetling, star of my liiiife, maybe now is not the time…?" Sea Hawk tried, but Mermista was on her feet.

"No. NO! I lost my ship for you people. Then we lose our harbour. And I nearly lost…" she bit back the last word, "And all because she didn't want to get her hands dirty, because…"

The hatch to the corridor hissed open and all heads turned. Faces paled and jaws clenched. Huntara straightened and licked her lips nervously.

Adora entered. But not in her rugged jacket and grey jumpsuit.

No, the Adora that entered conveyed lethality. Head to toe in black-and-red, a bodysuit that looked like an oily shadow, bulked out with armour and skirting that called to mind long-lost terrestrial warriors. Her face was concealed by a mask, smooth aside from a pair of red-gold lenses. Her hair emerged from the hood of the suit, perhaps impractical, but it looked more like some sort of plume of an ancient helm. Adora moved to the conference

table and hauled the jury-rigged chest-piece onto it, where it clattered. When she spoke, her voice seemed colder, clipped, "You asked for me."

Mermista stared, then sneered, "Oh, where was this when we needed it?"

Adora turned and Mermista flushed and stepped back a pace, "I didn't have the suit. What you wanted was for me to kill myself to make you happy. You wanted me to solve your problems. Problem *you* created because instead of just muddling along you kept. Poking. The. Horde. And now they have broken you. And you keep wanting to poke at them."

Mermista glared, "They nearly killed Sea Hawk!"

"Because you put yourself in their way. You thought they'd be lazy. You were an idiot. And you expected me to be there, to save you, to smack them about if they got a bit more challenging," Adora snorted, "I'm not sure what makes you different from them."

Angella actually coughed, "Adora that is hardly fair."

"It's not? They made me a weapon. You use me as one. They punished me if I did something wrong on a mission. You get upset I didn't nearly get myself killed in a losing battle?"

Silence fell and the room's occupants exchanged embarrassed glances. Mermista fumed and turned to leave, but Adora stepped in front of her. The Pirate Captain froze as the tall blonde stared at her. Mermista swallowed, "Yes?"

"We still need to plan."

"I thought you didn't *want* to," Mermista tried for a sneer, but the cold lenses of Adora's helmet made her pause and mollify her tone.

"We need to plan. But it's worthwhile laying out the *reality* of things. You all delayed, deferred and argued and I didn't push hard enough on things. Now you listen from the *start* . Is that understood?"

Faces scrunched up in consternation but Angella folded first, "Fine. If we can at least hear you out. And… why… where did the suit *come* from?"

Adora stared at Angella, then moved to the table. She keyed up something on her wrist and a holographic representation of the planetoid sprang up, showing the expanding debris field. Several areas flashed up in white and red, "These are points of interest that I have visited and catalogued - archaeological sites, old mines, abandoned depots. The sites in red are too dangerous *or* have been compromised by the Horde… or at least are likely to have been. They captured me from one of those locations. Our best bet is to move the fleet into one or several of these locations and then rotate the bulk between them, using the field to mask

the ships' presence. The Horde will move into a consolidation footing and likely not actively target you unless they have an easy opportunity to do so."

Glimmer stared at the display, then quirked her head to one side, "Wait… you said… us? But not you?"

Adora shrugged, "I am not sure what value I add. The fight is over. You survived. My suggestion is you rebuild *elsewhere* . The Empire will bring more and more here."

"We can't… can't just give up," Angella's face was distraught. She looked at Adora, forced herself to stare into that blank mask, "Why? Why are you giving up so easily?"

"You think it was easy to put this back on?" Adora's voice was flat, "No. This is on so I can get you where you need. And then I can get what *I* need."

"And then what?" Glimmer challenged. Adora stared at Angella, then looked at Glimmer.

"Not your concern. But I suggest you all leave."

Glimmer stared at her, then whispered, "You're staying aren't you? To fight them? But the plan was we regroup and fight!"

Adora shook her head, “They have something I need. And this system has… answers. That means I need to stay here. But you don’t. And I cannot spare my time keeping all of you safe. So hide. Or flee.”

“We can FIGHT!” Sea Hawk stepped forwards. Mermista stared at Adora, her face now one of confused irritation.

“Why are you saying we can’t?”

Adora met her gaze, then looked down at the table, “Because… because my mind is saying that for me to succeed I should either let you all charge in and provide enough of a distraction to give me a clear run. Or I should seize control of this fleet and fly it into that base… again, as a distraction. Any number of plans that are nasty, brutish and short.”

“It’s… controlling you?” whispered Juliet, her hand moving to her sidearm. Adora shook her head.

“No, but it gives me optimal plans. Synchronises and controls the things in me. I’m still me. But… it is very insistent on some ideas.”

“Which raises why you have it on. After all the… concern over the lack of suit it seems to be a terrible exchange,” mused Angella, a small frown on her face, “And again… where did it come from.”

“From the shuttle we seized,” Glimmer interjected, quickly, “We think… they may have brought it, to try to capture Adora.”

“All the more reason to not wear it!” Angella said, standing. Adora just chuckled coldly.

“I broke the suit’s controls a while ago, Angella. But I need it if I’m going to get my strongest weapon back.”

Juliet shook her head then laughed, more a bark than true mirth, “Well, you crazy bitch… you saved our lives. Even if the pirate there is an ungrateful idiot about it. You saved her boy toy after all. But you can’t ask us to flee. This is our *home* .”

“Then you may die,” Adora said, her voice displaying a tinge of sadness.

“Nah, we’re made of sterner stuff than THAT!” Sea Hawk proclaimed and flashed a roguish grin.

Adora regarded him then nodded slowly, “Alright.”

It was Huntara who stepped up next, “You want your ship back, right? So, we’re gonna set up a new hidey hole. Then you’re gonna, what, go in guns blazing?”

The blonde shook her head, “No. I need to find where Swiftwind is. Then I need to get him back. That… cannot be done rashly, but It’s going to be a focus. And… I need to talk to the prisoner.”

“Yeah,” winced Sea Hawk, “She… may not want to speak with you.”

Adora shrugged, “We don’t get what we want sometimes.”

—----------

Catra stared through the bars into the makeshift cell. She felt something twist in her gut and she had to swallow to suppress it. Kyle’s bruised face stared back at her from where he was slumped at the end of the cell. He tried for a weak smile, “H…hey Captain.”

She shook her head morosely and spoke sadly,, “Shut up Kyle.”

He sagged and nodded slowly, before he raised his head, “Lonnie?”

“In the wind.”

“Rogelio…?”

“Will be joining you shortly.”

He paled, under the bruises around his eyes and cheek, “Please, ma’am… it… it was all me. I blackmailed Lonnie, Rogelio. It… these aren’t bad people! They just wanted to escape.”

Catra stared at him coldly, “You don’t think I know that, Kyle? But we’re *soldiers* . We have our orders. We work within them. What you did…. It got people killed. It got your comrades *killed* , Kyle. By all rights I should have let the arresting detail just space you.”

They lapsed into silence, before Kyle spoke up, quietly, “Why didn’t you?”

Catra closed her eyes and had to turn away, “Because… I need to show the crew that it’s being done *properly.* By the stars Kyle… you guys tried to space *me* and… and I trusted you. I made a *deal* with you. And now I think, maybe… maybe I should’ve stuck with the handbook rules and had you all *shot* .”

Kyle winced and looked away, “Captain I…”

“And for… for what?”

"You had us escort… her. Those guidelines said she should've been secured and locked down HERE. Or executed," his voice trembled, "Instead you locked us on a ship with a *monster.* And… and she said she could save Lonnie and…"

Catra flinched but glared into the cell, "So this is *my* fault?"

Kyle met her gaze, then looked away, "I'm dead either way, right. So, kind of? But… yeah," he slumped, "So… what now?"

Catra massaged the bridge of her feline nose, "I… don't know. I don't know. But I know why at least."

With a heavy sigh she turned away from the cell and walked away, ignoring the guards that stood just outside of earshot. The knot of guilt coiled in her gut.

Take the loss, Adora .

She had her duty. And it felt worse every damn day.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Meetings and more meetings.

Catra's obligations get more complicated.

Adora is adding to her plans. What does she intend to do?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Rogelio grunted as the escorts shoved him along the corridor. He let out an irritated hiss which didn't translate and the guard just chuckled, his helmet vox-box making his voice sound almost robotic, "Yeah, can it, *traitor* . You'll be sucking vacuum with your boyfriend soon enough. And then the Captain will go space your girl when we get her back."

The reptile hissed again as a stun rod shocked him and he stumbled, half collapsing into the interrogation room. He snarled but fell silent as another voice cut through the air.

"Was the prisoner attempting to escape, Corporal?"

The escorts froze and coughed, with the offending soldier trying for belligerent obsequiousness, "Just, y'know, guaranteeing compliance, ma'am?"

Catra stood on the other side of the room's central metal table, in full dress uniform. She stared, blankly, at the soldier, then smirked, "And it's just that sort of independent thinking that got Lieutenant Rogelio here in trouble. Too much *initiative* , not enough *discipline* . You aren't thinking of emulating him, are you Corporal?"

"Ma'am, uh, no ma'am," the soldier answered, suddenly stiffening to attention. Catra shook her head slowly.

"And what if it turns out Rogelio here is innocent? Then it turns out you struck a superior officer. And imagine if you found yourself in his detail. He'd be within his rights to assume you'd be attempting to undermine him. He'd be *well* within his rights to put *you* on some pretty awful duties," she strolled leisurely around the table, her claws screeching across the metal surface. Her eyes remained fixed on the soldier, "Punishment on *my* orders only, Corporal. My commands. This isn't the battlefield, where pluck and ingenuity are useful. This is a ship, this is day to day. Otherwise I'll assume you don't know how to follow orders, that you are as *defective* as these potential traitors. And I will have to continue to set examples until people. Damn. Well. Learn."

She was now right up in his face. Although she was shorter, she managed to loom. Her eyes narrowed and the soldier swallowed, his vox box amplifying the noise, "Ma'am."

"I'm glad we understand each other. Now, return to your post, no more… free thinking. Or I'll have you on EVA welding with the bots. Dismissed."

The soldiers saluted and backed out. Catra glanced at Rogelio, then gestured to the chair. She walked back around the table and sat stiffly down. The reptile sat and fixed Catra with an uncertain gaze. They regarded one another in silence for a moment before Catra blew out a breath. Rogelio gurgled a question, which came out through a speaker in the room's ceiling as the local translator kicked in, " *Is…. is Kyle safe?"*

"For now," Catra drawled. She stared at Rogelio. The lizard rumbled again.

"And… Lonnie? I heard the Destroyer was hit."

Catra regarded the reptile, then flipped open a paper folder in front of her. She pursed her lips, then spun it around to slide across the desk, "Scenes from the Hangar security cams. Lieutenant Lonnie Dav, Number IHN223758, currently MIA, suspected of sedition, mutiny and aiding the enemy during an active combat situation."

Rogelio stared at the images. One of Lonnie in the company of the former prisoners, then of her over the shoulder of a rugged looking man. Rogelio's tail lashed and it drew a derisive snort from the Captain. He looked up and rumbled, *"She does not look willing. Taken prisoner. Coerced."*

"Is that the story you're going with?" Catra drawled. Her hands were clasped in front of her, but she unthreaded her fingers and drummed her claws against the table, making a clack clacking sound as their tips scraped steel, "Think *very* carefully before you

lie to me, *Lieutenant* . I have Kyle in the brig. I have a psychotic AI that, while near catatonic, still can access records. I have *witnesses* . Do not. Push. Me."

Rogelio stared into his commanding officer's mismatched eyes. They were angry, cold and… sad. He couldn't help but shrink back a little. A few hours prior he'd been flying a patrol, before his wing had been ordered to land back on the Destroyer. He'd clambered out of his fighter, only to be tackled by several soldiers, who had hauled him aboard a shuttle, shackled him and then deposited him in a security room for hours, before hauling him here. And now he was under the furious gaze of one of the most dangerous people he knew.

"We… I… I knew Kyle was safe. We… we communicated with the Rebels, to secure his release."

"And the *price* ?" Catra seethed.

"We said no deaths. We… We agreed to free prisoners. That was all. An exchange."

"And it didn't occur to you to, oh I don't know, *alert your chain of command* ?" Catra growled out through clenched teeth. She stood and her chair clattered back, "Didn't think that, maybe, you were being *played* ?"

"It was the Praetorian! I have never seen Lonnie so scared, so certain of Kyle's death! She…. she saw what the Praetorian did. She was sure it was the lesser path. That it would not lead to the Praetorian coming to the Destroyer, or just… murdering Kyle. It is why she took him, Lonnie said. Leverage."

Catra stared at him, then sagged and chuckled, humourlessly, "Exactly as I expected," she snorted at Rogelio's confused look, "Honestly? As soon as Kyle was nabbed and Lonnie was left alive… I could spot a plant. I'm not an *idiot* Rogelio. Oh sure, you and a few of the crew rebelled and thought you had me over a barrel once before. You didn't want the regs, the stupid, pointless routines. You wanted a looser regime, a relaxed ship. You wanted to pierce the void!" Catra leaned down and righted her chair, before she flopped down in it, "And y'know what, I was *a bitch* back then. Screaming, shouting, threatening. Not great. But I actually agreed. A chance to just be… a bit free. Right? I guess you all thought because I decided to go along with the plan, compromised, it was good? Never thought I could have just vented atmosphere, couldn't have shot you all? Didn't think I had the numbers?"

Rogelio rumbled and shrugged, " *We were angry. Just wanted to do the job, be a small dot in the system."*

"And you'd have spaced me on the spot if I hadn't agreed, wouldn't you. No second glance."

Silence hung in the air. Rogelio shifted uncomfortably. He tried for a shrug but wouldn't meet her eyes for a moment, before he managed to raise his head, " *We wanted to force you, to scare you. Some of the crew did. But I do not think we would have."*

Catra stared at him, then scoffed, "Hm. Well, you have been *oh so helpful* . As of now you are consigned to the brig, awaiting trial. Lonnie will be recovered and tried, likely after your sentences have been carried out."

" *Please, it was us. Kyle was… he was coerced."*

"He failed as a soldier of the Empire. He was an active conspirator."

"As if you have not bent rules and…"

Catra's hands slammed into the desk and she leaned across the table, "I *tried* to keep things simple. Keep it *oh so simple* . I tried to be *kind* . To be *merciful* . To be what YOU ALL wanted me to be. To spare civilians, to show some…. Measure of restraint. And look where we are now, hm? Forefront of the damn fight against…. Miners. Traders. Rebels. Because kindness gets you *nowhere* . I tried being the good soldier, the good commander, the renegade with a heart," she sneered, "AND LOOK WHERE IT GOT US! You thinking you can screw around? Your comrades *died* . People on the Destroyer Vengeance *died* in that peaceful escape attempt. The vessel was sabotaged - imagine if those *poor rebels* had managed to trigger a self destruct? Or commandeered a weapons system. As it was, they hijacked two Imperial ships and made their escape."

Rogelio stared at her, " *But… you said you knew she or I would try something."*

“I foolishly had faith in my subordinates to stop it,” she waved a hand dismissively, “And I had to know. Now, I think we are *done* here.”

She stalked towards the door, but paused, to lean against the wall. Rogelio fidgeted for a moment, then looked over his shoulder, “ *What… is to become of us* ?”

“Sentencing is to be confirmed. But you know the penalty for mutiny and sedition. I will… try to make it quick,” Catra’s voice was dull. With a huff she straightened, then glanced back at Rogelio, a tired look on her face, “I’ll have them put you opposite Kyle. I’m not a complete monster.”

The door hissed open and Catra stepped out into the corridor. Rogleio folded his hands on the table and stared, blankly, at nothing.

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Scorpia met Catra as the Captain strode through the promenade, “Ma’am, how’d it, uh, go?”

Catra shrugged, “Confession, or most of one. We can interrogate for more details, but it feels pointless. Anything to update?”

"Um, Entrapta has the latest feedback from the testing on-planet. She has a prototype already set up! And, um… there's a priority message. From, uh, Regional Commander Hordak."

Catra stumbled and cursed, "Fine, I'll take it in the comm room."

"And uh… is… is there a decision about… the traitors?" Scorpia rubbed her claws together nervously. Catra just shrugged and strode away.

"You know the regs."

She left a nervy Scorpia behind her as she stalked through the corridors of the asteroid base. The feline pushed into the command centre and strode across it, into the private comm room. She straightened her uniform then tapped in several commands to signal ready for a communique from the Regional Commander.

She had to wait for fifteen minutes, as clearly the man wasn't exactly hanging around for *her* . As she studied her nails, a chirp from the unit announced a connection. A hologram shivered to life, depicting a tall, gaunt man with almost bat-like features - a flat nose, red eyes and pointed, elongated ears. His hair was slicked back in the style of the central, core systems, and his uniform of dark blue and grey was pressed and neat. His cold gaze fixed on Catra.

"I understand there has been… progress."

"Aye, sir. Reporting that the main stronghold of the rebellion has been secured, their forces scattered, local assets secured. Also, we have captured the aberrant vessel."

Hordak studied her for a moment, " *And its pilot?"*

"Was… being transported out of system, before an unknown ship failure, sir. She…" Catra flinched a little, then shrugged, "She may have escaped. The vessel shifted course and impacted another Horde vessel. Also, her escape compromised three Horde troopers, who facilitated an attempted to disrupt operations, but we anticipated this and were able to minimise the impact. Casualty and material losses and in the attached report. I recommend sending the compromised troops to the ember mines in…"

" *Just execute them and be done with it. I expect to see the confirmations, Captain. Treachery must be snuffed out, without mercy."*

"Sir, they… they are soldiers in good standing. This was," she grimaced, "An act of masterful coercion by… a skilled operator. Playing on their camaraderie. Any soldier would feel conflicted."

"It does not matter. A soldier's loyalty is to the Emperor first. All else is secondary. They should rather put their service weapon to

their temple than betray their oaths. As such it is your duty, Captain, to ensure the required punishments are carried out. Lest it fester. You know this more than most."

"Sir… I did take over an entire fleet. Do you wish for me to order my *own* execution?" she narrowed her eyes. Hordak met her glare unflinchingly.

" *Spare me the facetious commentary, Captain. Your actions were ambitious and aligned with Imperial objectives, as you yourself said. And you SUCCEDED. Do not tar that success with some misguided nobility. Expedite this. I expect this to be done, Captain. And ensure the prototype is prepared, along with the original unit. I arrive in seventy two hours."*

Catra blinked suddenly, "You're… coming here? Sir, we have it all…"

"Captain Catra Driluth. Do not make me repeat myself again. Your sector is of great interest. You have achieved much, but are… not seasoned enough to manage an entire system of such valuable assets without my validating your competence. I expect all things to be prepared for my arrival."

The hologram vanished with a flicker. Catra's fists clenched and she let out a yowling growl of frustration, along with a "SHIT!" for good measure.

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Lonnie shifted and grunted with irritation as her shackles rattled. She was cuffed to several laden cargo crates in the bay of some cramped hauler. She had no real idea which one out of the rag-tag fleet they'd dragged her to was the vessel. No idea of its name, where they were or anything. She'd been groggy on the escape from the *Vengeance* and her jaw ached a bit from the punch. Her grand plan had gone horribly wrong in a multitude of ways and, though she was reluctant to admit it, she knew there was now blood on her hands.

Seeing the refugees - there was no other word for it, really - and their fleet out of the porthole of the gunship had driven it home, though, what the Horde was doing was… off. She'd not had much choice in signing up, mostly for the free food and board. But there had been, initially, that feeling of being part of something stable, something bigger. And then, after she'd gotten irritated with the regimented attitudes, the endless, pointless bits of bureaucracy, that there was potential for a more realistic service on the fringes.

Catra had nearly screwed that with her doctrinal, angry approach, but that mutiny had seemed to work and the woman had mellowed. Lonnie even respected her, seeing that the woman was competent. And that she did seem to genuinely care, after a fashion.

Up until this whole cascade of insanity that had unfurled since meeting that devil in human form. Then Catra had gone all in. Not some core-world bureaucratic officer, but a terrifyingly focused war-machine instead. The weird tech, the rebel presence and the

Praetorian . It had all snowballed and with Kyle being taken, Lonnie hadn't seen an easy way out.

Part of her knew she should have, maybe…. Trusted Catra. But another part of her blamed the Captain for putting her on board the same ship as that *creature* .

She glanced up as the entrance to the cargo hold hissed open and she heard the shuffling of boots as the couple of guards in the bay with her turned to greet the arrival. She heard a couple of curses, the voices clearly shocked. Lonnie frowned, then shrunk back as a tall figure strode around a crate and came to a stop in front of her.

Adora stared down at Lonnie, her face obscured behind a mask, leaving only her piercing blue eyes to bore into the Horde soldier. The black and red Praetorian armour, which looked almost like cloth and thin plates of elegant metal, glinted in the running lights that spanned the cargo hold. The Praetorian cocked her head from side to side, then nodded slowly. She squatted down in front of Lonnie, her eyes unblinking. Lonnie wasn't sure, but she swore there was a glint of red in those eyes.

"Hello, Lonnie. I have some questions," the voice came out vaguely synthesised from the mask, slightly mechanical. Gone was the tired, almost manic voice from the Frigate, replaced by this dispassionate, distant sound.

"I… I did what you wanted. What more…"

“Shush. I ask, you tell.”

Lonnie glared, “No. You *promised* , your *threatened* and now look at me. I don’t even know…”

“Kyle is safe. We left him unharmed. Of course, it depends if the Horde have acted against him. But that was on you to deal with.”

“You lied to me. The prisoners were just supposed to escape and…”

“They’re pirates. What did you think would happen? You were on the ground. You were in control. That’s your failing, not mine.”

“And… Rogelio?” Lonnie glared at Adora. The blonde shrugged, her ponytail shifting as the woman cocked her head again.

“The… oh the reptile? I recognised the grunting. We don’t know Horde casualties. He wasn’t on the Destroyer?”

“He was a pilot.”

“Unknown. We shot down a couple of your fighters. I can ask.”

Lonnie stared into those blue eyes and then snorted, “You don’t look better.”

“Because I’m not. Now, questions.”

“No.”

Adora sighed, “We need your help. I’m asking. You’re stuck with us. Helping us helps you.”

“Go space yourself. I’m screwed. Probably a traitor. That means Kyle and Rogelio are in the same capsule. You have *screwed* me.”

Adora sighed, then fished a thin knife from somewhere on her person. She tossed it in one hand, catching it by the hilt, “Which eye is your dominant one?” Lonnie’s breathing increased and her nostrils flared while she tried to cringe back. Adora looked between her eyes, “Do you know the incoming vessel scheduling and the system jump in points?”

Lonnie glared, “I can’t”

The blonde tapped the blade against a finger tip and paused. She stared at the knife, then back at Lonnie, before she shuddered. Slowly, deliberately, she resheathed the blade and stood, turning

away from the prisoner. She shook her head and muttered, "Sorry."

The Horde soldier shuddered, confused, "Why are you doing this? I HELPED you!"

Adora's voice was quieter now, "Because your people still absolutely smashed us. You helped, yes, but you were on a ship full of people who would have done… things to me. I know you don't condone it. And I even held back… when the rest of you came for my friends. But now…"

Another voice cut through the air, "Adora! No!"

Lonnie practically sagged with relief as a familiar, pink haired girl shoved her way around the crates, a glare on her face. Adora stared, but Lonnie couldn't see her face from where she was shackled, "Hey Glimmer. Got your friend here, but she's not exactly opening up. I was hoping she'd be a bit more co-operative after we saved her from being court martialed."

"You *just* said I could have avoided it if I'd stayed!" Lonnie snarled. Adora shrugged.

"Honestly, did you really rate your chances? Or were you lining up your earliest escape opportunity? Because if you weren't, then how you made Lieutenant I have no idea."

Lonnie looked at Glimmer, "I am NOT speaking to HER. Twice now, and she's been *this* close to murdering people. No way can I trust her. She's been…. Nothing but a pain, a problem."

Adora just shrugged again, " *Nothing happened,* Glimmer. I'm… in control."

"Yeah, right," Lonnie barked. Glimmer frowned at Adora, then shook her head.

"I get you're… angry, Adora. So, please keep a handle on it, for me? And you," she looked at Lonnie, then sighed, "I know this is a mess. And… I wanted to thank you. On the planet. For helping."

Adora stepped back and leaned against a crate, eyes on Lonnie, "For what it's worth… you did help. We saved a lot of lives, thanks to what you did."

Lonnie looked at the deck plating, "Yeah, but we lost lives too."

"And we didn't? People who just wanted to stay in their homes, now stuck on freighters. Family they'll never see again because they stayed behind? Knowing that if we HAD stayed, we'd have been shipped off, or catalogued, or… whatever the Empire decided it wanted to do?" Glimmer's voice was hard, "We've all lost people. Today, before. It's all been… hard. But, thank you. You

saved innocent lives. Civilian lives. Which is what a soldier SHOULD do."

The Horde soldier squirmed, then deflated. Her voice was quiet, "Yeah. I guess."

"And, I know this will be hard, but we need your help again. To keep us alive."

"I can't," Lonnie shook her head, "You'll kill more people. I can't betray them any more… don't ask me that."

"What do you want?" Adora queried, her voice still oddly mechanical. Lonnie snorted and looked up.

" *Excuse* me? Why I'd *love* to not be shackled up. I'd love a decent meal. Maybe a shower. Oh, some nice quarters."

Adora straightened, then advanced to loom over Lonnie. The soldier stared up at the Praetorian, defiance in her eyes, despite the tremor in her limbs. Glimmer stepped forwards, with an "Adora" coming from her lips.

The Praetorian reached down and tapped the shackles. There was a green glow, sickly and electrical, then the cuffs unlocked. Adora stepped back to her lounging position and crossed her arms, "Step one. What else?"

Lonnie blinked, absently massaging her wrists. She narrowed her eyes, looking between the two women in front of her, "I think I asked for food and a shower."

Glimmer snorted and looked at Adora who shrugged, before she returned her gaze to Lonnie, "No showers. But we can probably get you some grub. Rations only, though. We're not as… well fitted out here, right now."

"Where are we anyway?" Lonnie probed. Adora just barked a laugh.

"Not your concern yet. So, what else? Seems you are capable of answering some questions."

Lonnie shrugged, "When I'm inclined. Alright. You want my help, you live up to your deal. You keep Kyle safe. But since you screwed that, now there's an extra - Rogelio. Them, safe, I help."

Glimmer grimaced and Adora just laughed, "Spring two prisoners from a base your people just took and are reinforcing?"

Lonnie glared at Adora, "I thought you were some scary Praetorian."

“Rescue wasn’t exactly a *common* mission,” the blonde mused, “Glimmer?”

The pink haired girl folded her arms over her purple-pink coveralls, “We lived up to our obligations, but… I see your point. First, some more faith. Ship arrivals in system. I promise we will *minimise* casualties where we can. But we need to know,” she glanced atAdora, as if unsure of the why of the question, but the Praetorian nodded. Lonnie watched their exchange.

“Why?”

Adora gazed at the woman, then looked to Glimmer. The pink haired girl gave her a nonplussed look in return and Adora sighed before she answered, “The gunships and transport have recognisable IFF cores. We can change and hack them, but we need relevant replacement IDs. And for those we need an uncompromised large-scale Horde database… which we can get from incoming freighters. And if we get some of *those* , we have additional ships which we can use as well. A freighter would mean we can smuggle items in and out, under patrol’s noses. For a time, anyway. We can spoof enough IDs to ensure the ships here don’t spot us and the patrols *outside* the system assume it’s a freighter FROM this system.”

Lonnie blinked, “A *heist* ? That’s what you want me to help with? Piracy?”

“Why not?” Adora chuckled, “You tried it on me…”

The memory of their first encounter with Adora made Lonnie flinch. It was hard to admit that what the Empire did was barely a step above piracy at times. Not for the first time she felt that flush of shame. She stood up and rolled her shoulders to try to distract herself from that unpleasant revelation and to give her a moment to marshal her thoughts. Eventually she let out a sigh, “I can give you a couple of jump locales where the Regional Command has been sending in ships, but I don’t know the routine or rota by heart. You’ll have to get that some other way.”

Adora nodded slowly, “It’s a start. Wasn’t too hard now, was it?”

Lonnie glared at Adora, “And your end of the bargain?”

“I’ll see what I can do,” the blonde replied, “Having some new Horde IFFs will *help* in that, though. See? You help us, we help you. It all works out,” her voice was actually almost friendly, earnest, for a moment. Lonnie just shook her head, then looked at Glimmer.

“So. Food?”

Chapter End Notes

> Likely this one will be a bit slower. I'm still aiming for 6 chapters for this, as I'm hoping it'll be a bit faster paced as we see how their plans all unfold...

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Scorpia ponders the reality of things.

Catra makes plans within plans.

And the Rebels seem to have some good news, everyone!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The atmosphere on the station was tense. The impending arrival of the Sector Governor had everyone on edge; some with anticipation, as junior officers gossiped about the impending medals, citations and other expected rewards. The more experienced Non-commissioned troopers had a more realistic outlook: it's never good when the big brass steps down to the mud and muck. They're there to crack the whip or steal the glory.

Or maybe both.

Scorpia made her way through the station, having spent a few moments down in the cells, catching snippets of conversation as she moved. Guards chattered quietly, while crackling comms reported in the status of repairs and ongoing searches.

The Rebels had left a lot of things behind and, in time-honored "tradition", the Horde troopers were helping themselves to valuables and "spoils of war". The Captain had ordered military assets and electronics to be collated, but miscellaneous stuff was

being stacked and sorted in various bays and holds for distribution among troopers. It was unpleasant, but was being overseen by Sergeants who were stopping it turning into *chaotic* looting.

It was still uncomfortable for Scorpia to see and was yet another weight on her. She joined up to fight for her Empire. To protect people, to strike at pirates and invaders. But she also knew that, out here, isolated, far from home, the Troops had to make do. And the people on this station *had* fought against them, sheltered enemies and pirates. She nodded to herself.

Speaking, briefly, to Kyle and Rogelio had muddied that. What they had done offended her sensibilities of duty and, well, *family* . The Military WAS her family and for people to do that was abhorrent. If you couldn't trust the crew around you to follow orders, to execute commands, then you were a single bad decision from the vacuum.

She was currently off duty - Catra had tasked her with prepping the *Vengeance* for a perimeter patrol to "discourage" any of the Rebels from trying some hare-brained scheme to retake the base. But Scorpia didn't think that was likely. And, really, she didn't think Catra thought that either.

It was all this preparation for Hordak's arrival. Everyone was grabbing a few hours down time where they could before the inevitable chaos of senior staff arriving. Scorpia shook her head and hummed at herself in mock admonishment - no need to start getting *antsy* about her superiors. Catra was her superior and was *very* capable. No reason to think Hordak wouldn't be similar. But her friend seemed to be growing more tense as the hours passed. She'd been full of fire before this assault but since the victory

Catra seemed almost twitchy. The betrayal by Lonnie and the others had cut deep at them, but perhaps in a way that Catra, nor Scorpia, had really thought about. But, really, it wasn't their *job* to do that - to make those moral calls or the "big big" decisions. They had a job, they did it as effectively as they could. And they'd done what they could to keep casualties light. Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio had messed with that and *could* have killed a lot more.

But, in some part of her soul, Scorpia respected that camaraderie; that loyalty to one another. She'd thought it had extended to Catra and herself, but now… now it felt that this was greyer than she'd anticipated. They were soldiers, they had objectives, they had to follow orders to achieve them. And for all Kyle's words, she wondered if their actions had been motivated by sincerity to help innocents or just… self preservation.

Didn't necessarily make the statement about the civilians *wrong* … Scorpia shook her head and huffed, which drew a worried glance from a couple of junior troopers. They snapped salutes, which she returned, absently.

Honestly, she also missed Entrapta. They spoke, briefly, in the updates on the woman's progress, but not much else was covered. And the purple haired engineer seemed lost in her discoveries. It was always fun to watch her vanish down a proverbial tunnel. But this time there was something else there - a focus and almost manic joy that was a little unnerving to see. The captured vessel had her absolutely fascinated. She wondered if a personal visit back to the ice-rock that their base was hidden on might not be a bad idea.

Scorpia’s wanderings led her to a door. She blinked in surprise, realising she’d walked down the wrong corridor into the station’s hydroponics quarters - she had been aiming for the bar that was hewn into the rock of the ‘roid, on the promenade.

Idly, she studied the door and noted, with satisfaction, that no one had tried to breach or loot here: Soldiers were opportunists, yes, but they all knew you don’t screw with several fundamental things: The engines, the oxygen and the Sergeant’s coffee.

She peered through the glass window atop the pressure door and blinked in surprise. Her claw drifted over and pushed the access button, which caused the door to hiss open, allowing her into the small, bubble-like airlock. The bubble was transparent and, basically, just a way to ensure the clear humidity and moisture didn’t leak out every time the door was opened.

She’d seen hydroponics bays ons citations and even on the few supply haulers she’d served on; heck, even the *Vengeance* had a rudimentary one: a few plants in sad little troughs, helping to cycle the oxygen on the sealed, metal box that was a starship.

But this…. This was a *garden* .

It was orderly, yes, but only in that there was some sort of plan underlying the explosion of colours and winding vines. The faint sound of water trickling through irrigation units and the hum of air-circulators were the only technological interruptions to the wash of greenery that sprawled across rows and rows of trays. There were avenues, shaded by overhanging trees and grasping

fronds. Flowers and fruits wafted their scents into the air, which drew Scorpia into the depths of the garden.

She paused to gently touch a cactus-like thing, all bulbous and spiny. Her breath caught and she swallowed, her mind filled with memories of sand and a pair of smiling, happy faces. She coughed and shook herself, trying to force a smile back to her face. Her chest panged for a world a thousand or more light years away. Somewhere she hadn't seen in… too long.

Scorpia continued down the line and paused at an open spot. A bench and worktable were set up here, with a scattering of abandoned tools. Old cuttings withered, but a few hardy ones lived on in isolated ceramic pots. Scorpia traced her claw across the space, her mind briefly dwelling on the people who had been her, working this space, maintaining such… beauty.

A terminal affixed to the bench flickered to life and Scorpia startled, but then froze again. A tanned face, framed by frizzy blonde hair, smiled from the screen and then spoke; her voice was bubbly, but a little cautious, as she rambled: " *Um, hello!. If you are watching this, then I guess we have lost the station, died in a space plague or managed to find somewhere long term!"* the face beamed happily out of the screen, then chuckled, " *Though why I'd leave a message for that last one I have NO idea. No chance I'd have left all my little ones if we'd been able to move! So, I suppose something bad happened. In that case, I am speaking to you, the new owners, visitors or hopeful souls who have inherited our once happy home. I hope it's all functional and to your liking!"*

Scorpia stared at the image - there was no guile there, no sarcasm. True, she often found it hard to spot or respond to it,

but she could tell. No, this woman seemed wholly genuine. Scorpia leaned against the table and cocked her head to one side, fascinated.

The woman continued, " *If all is still functional then the hydroponics bay should still be functional. The water reserves, air circulation and nutrient supplements are pretty robust and automated. And it doesn't hurt that our crop is pretty resilient and doesn't need all that much! Necessity… but still, something to be admired and…. Preserved,"* she smiled hopefully out of the screen, *"If you are here to scavenge or resupply, please help yourself. I just have one request - if you can preserve the life here, the work we have done - please do. I look at this garden and see our little universe. Full of potential, vibrancy, colour and… life. Flourishing against the odds. So, all I ask is that you preserve it, in some way, however you can. Because don't all things deserve a chance? If you cannot, then I wish you well anyway and hope that our little oasis has brought you something at least. Safe travels."*

The screen winked off and Scorpia stared at it for a moment. She tapped the screen and the video sprung to life again, repeating. The Scorponi woman watched, fascinated as the woman went through her talk again. She watched it a third, then a fourth time, as a frown knitted its way across her forehead.

It was only the crackle of her comm unit that pulled her away from the video. She fumbled at her badge and tapped it to open the channel, "C-Commander Scorpia, go ahead."

" *Scorp, need you in my office. Now. Out."*

Catra's clipped tones sounded off, loud in the quiet of the hydroponics bay. Scorpia didn't get a chance to respond before it cut off. She stared at the now-blank screen for a moment, before she fished her personal data tablet from the pouch on her utility belt. She affixed it to the terminal then identified the video and copied it. With a slow nod, she turned and moved out of the bay, leaving behind the faint plink of water and the rustle of leaves.

Five minutes later she stood in front of Catra's desk in an at ease pose. The magicat in front of her looked tired, drawn and *cranky.* Scorpia waited for her CO to speak. For her part, the Captain just sifted through a stack of data pads. She scoffed.

"Digital reports, but they need individual *pads* ? And paper ones *too* ? Eugh," she sagged back in her chair and stared at Scorpia, "Where's the fun, huh, Scorp? Where's the kicking ass and taking names?"

"We, uh, did that… already, ma'am?"

"It's why I have you. You deal with this," muttered Catra. She shook her head, "Except I guess I do *too* ?"

"Is… is that what you wanted to talk about, Wildcat?" Scorpia asked, tentatively, "I have the Vengeance being readied and resupplied, maintenance is underway, but we can undertake the patrol…"

"It's… it's the traitors," Catra's voice was cold. She drummed her fingers on the table and swallowed, then looked up at Scorpia, "I'm… going to space them, Scorpia. No firing squad."

The Commander's eyes went wide, "But… that's…"

"Going to give them *suits* and a supply of oxygen. I won't make our people shoot our people. Yeah, it'll… give them a sense of satisfaction for a split *second* … but then it starts the whole 'yeah but you happily shot Kyle' talk and… no. I'll do it myself. Push the button. Sends a message."

Scorpia swallowed, "A… trial, surely?"

"No. No time. Orders. Like I said before, *regs* ," her eyes searched Scorpia's for a moment and she drew a breath through her nose before she looked away, "I… don't want you here for it. But… but I need you to *help* ."

The final word leaked out of Catra like it was less and order, more a plea. Scorpia broke her stance and stepped forward, only to halt as Catra hissed in warning. The Captain rocked in her chair for a moment, only sparing Scorpia a brief glance. The Commander coughed, gently, "Help, ma'am?"

"Yes. Pre the suits, ensure they have… enough. I… I'm not a monster. No vacuum freeze."

“Shooting might be kinder,“ mumbled Scorpia. Catra snarled.

“But it is *final* …” the word hung in the air and Scorpia frowned.

“That’s the… point?” she trailed off, her mind slowly tripping over, “You want to space them… with suits… with enough supplies to last… but they could…?” she stumbled over the weirdness of the idea.

“No. Not enough to *last* , Scorpia. Enough to suffer, obviously. To understand their fate, in the void, that they condemned others to, obviously. With *no chance* of any one coming to their *rescue . ”*

Scorpia was confused. Her claws clacked together, “You’ll be seen as… as a monster.”

“No. As someone you do not cross. And they will be… gone. Somewhere else. And my own authority sure, the loyalty of the crew assured. They know I won’t tolerate people who would hurt *them* , even my own close crew. The High Command see me as a disciplinarian, able to hold a fringe fleet together, unafraid to *act* . You getting it, Scorp? And the guilty get everything they deserve.” Catra turned her eyes back on Scorpia, “Maybe talk to the condemned. Understand if they have any final wishes, any… messages to loved ones back home to convey. Not my job. I’m the executioner. Nothing they want to tell me, anyway… So, dismissed.”

Scorpia was *very* confused, “Ma’am?”

“Do I need to repeat myself, Commander?” Catra growled and pulled a pile of data pads in front of her. She began to blindly scroll through them, then glanced up, “Go!”

Scorpia nodded, mind a fog. She was pretty sure she had an inkling of what Catra had said, but she wasn’t *sure* . Her mind abuzz with too many ideas and memories, she made for the cells, fairly sure she knew what she had to do. Just not quite sure *how* .

Behind her, in her office, Catra sagged and clutched at the fur at her temples. With a snarl, she swept the data pads from her desk and let out a low hiss which morphed into a gurgled sob. She drew a breath, then straightened and adjusted her tunic, before she stood to retrieve them. The feline sat at her desk, eyes cool, but wet as she continued in her duty.

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“So, what are we looking at?” Angella hummed as their gathering stared at a blown up hologram of the planetoid. Some of the Markers Adora had singled out were highlighted green, others blue, some amber and a select few in red. Bow grinned from across the display at her.

“A *goldmine* , ma’am. ANd one that, frankly, I’m shocked we didn’t jump all over before.”

“That’s because it’s a nightmare to navigate the planetoid,” chuckled Huntara. She sat on a crate next to the display, but regarded it intently, “Sensors go screwy and there are… things in there. Likely to rip your ship in two as to ignore you.”

“Yet Adora navigated it,” murmured Angella.

“That she did. She did have a cheat, with her ship, of course,” Bow chuckled. He indicated the display, “You had her fighting… but we should have been asking her about *prospecting* . So, from what she’s given me, these sites in green are potential habitation zones. Space to put our people, atmosphere, potential to even have sustainable storage. Even *growing* areas - some of these locations have *plant life!”*

Huntara shook her head, “What? It’s a wrecked rock!”

“I know, weird as ANYTHING! But there’s power, infrastructure. We’d have to be careful, but we can piggy back in some of these areas. Spread our people out.”

“Doesn’t that make them vulnerable to being picked off?” mused Angella. Bow shrugged.

“Same risk as having everyone in one spot - easier to track us to *one* location. Multiples, means they’re uncertain. Now, the blue points are solid places for military assets - resupply points, near the edge of the nebulous zones. Transit points, chokepoints… the amber zones are… limited utility. Single corridors, or just open bays with not much, but *could* be useful for temporary RV points, supply cache drops or… well, whatever. And the red zones…”

“Compromised by the Horde?” Huntara grunted, “Yeah, guess that one.”

Bow nodded, “And navigation is… going to be a bit tricky. But Adora has given us the routes. She’s offering to help set up beacons keyed only to our systems or a specific code matrix. Which means our ships can dive in and navigate.”

“She was followed, though, right?” Angella gestured at the map, “And she’s supposedly… good at avoiding things.”

“Yeah she’s… annoyed at that,” chuckled Bow, morosely, “But she thinks it was a specific probe, and she wasn’t flying too evasively. They were also tracking her ship *specifically*. Ours, much harder. We know the Horde has sensor drones throughout the system. We *thought* it was for surveying but Adora now thinks it was just for her. They still have an extensive sensor view of most of the system… but we can use our stolen Horde ships to some degree. The IFF codes will be logged as hostile, but Adora has scrambled them temporarily until we can grab new ones.”

Angella rolled her eyes and smiled, “Bow, I am an administrator, not a technician. Please, speak plainly.”

“We can use our ships to approach those drones, input data to *hide* our ships!” He beamed, happily. Huntara actually leaned backwards and grinned.

“You’re pulling my chain?” she huffed, “For real?”

“Yeah, before now we had to avoid ships… because no way can you hack each Horde ship to blindside an ID code, right? Or have your ship NOT have a code and just be an unknown - they’d assume you were suspect either way? But NOW… now it’s a vulnerability! Or temporarily. Long term, new, solid IFFs for the ships to allow us to use them as infiltrators would be good, but our civilian ships can at least mask or confuse the system *potentially* .”

He grinned at them, practically bouncing on the balls of his feet. Angella and pursed her lips, arched her eyebrows and nodded approvingly, “Well well. Quite the thing.”

Huntara chuckled, “So… where is our guardian angel?”

Bow winced, “Being shouted at by Lonnie. She keeps asking about… raiding the base, rescuing her friends… all that.”

"Not likely," Huntara scoffed, "Adora's good, but boarding a station *and* extracting two prisoners? She would be fine, but no chance they wouldn't get tagged and KIA…" the big woman shook her head, "So, I guess we're stuck. Adora going to go ahead and screw with their sensor net?"

"Already got Mermista and her teams doing runs. My engineers are doing the actual jamming and jury rigging. We have to do them at irregular intervals, as the net does go down - but given the size of the sensor net, we can get *most* of them. We'll have to adjust a few as we identify where they are, as we don't know the location of every satellite or sensor… but we can likely get a major coverage sorted. Just gotta do it slowly," Bow winced, "It's not an *immediate* solution."

Angella sighed, "These things never are," she glanced over as the cargo door hissed open. Juliet strode in and nodded to the other three.

"Ma'am, the rest of the flotilla is prepped. We need a decision on movement - the captains are getting antsy. A few are thinking of making a break for it… but Imperial chatter is going haywire."

"Oh?" Angella frowned, "What do you mean?"

"Big fleet movements outside the system, seeing a lot of cargo being redirected to a neighbouring jump point, if the comms we've managed to tap from the base are any indicator. They haven't found *all* the leaks," Juliet chuckled, but her face was serious, "Seems like they're due an inspection. So we may see an influx of supply ships."

Huntara growled, “Potential pickings.”

“Or a trap,” Angella winced, “We can’t be reckless, striking out after such a recent loss. They’d be expecting us to try that. That, or flee. No… no, your and… Adora’s suggestions have merit, Bow. Let us go… here.”

She gestured at the map and Bow nodded. He made a note on a digi-pad he clutched in one hand, then ran his writing hand down the side of his coveralls, “Ok, let’s get the location keyed into the flotilla’s navicoms and… I guess I’ll ask Adora to lead the way.”

He saluted Angella and departed the bay, leaving the trio of women to survey the hologram further, stalking through to find an airlock that connected this freighter to another one - the one with the prisoner. And their resident killer-for-hire.

He grimaced at the thought. Adora fully embracing her Praetorian armour was disconcerting. The holdover suit he and Casta had jury rigged, with input from Perfuma’s biotechnological know-how had seemed to have at least given Adora a sense of independence. But it hadn’t been the long term solution. She seemed to think that *that* lay with her ship. Which did beg the question - why hadn’t the ship solved the issue *already* ?

He wondered if it was because Adora still used the suit and… reinforced its hold on her, somehow. He was no-where near well-

versed in Imperial nano-tech to make a judgement, of course, but it felt… right. Something to ponder

Bow found Lonnie, Glimmer and Adora alone in the makeshift canteen of the freighter - it was clear the rest of the crew had left in a hurry. The three ate in silence - or rather, Lonnie and Glimmer ate. The blonde was leaning against the bulkhead, staring into the middle distance. Slowly, Bow approached and slid onto the bench next to Glimmer. It had been a few hours since Lonnie had agreed to help, in exchange for freeing her compromised friends. As Bow sat, the tannoy chimed with a message: *"Greyskull to the bridge. Repeat, Greyskull to the bridge."*

Adora said nothing, just straightened and headed out. Lonnie tracked her, her whole body tense. But it was Glimmer who broke the silence, "Problem?"

"You all ok with *that* walking around?" Lonnie shook her head, "Like, unsupervised?"

Glimmer stared at the woman then shrugged, "She hasn't hurt us. But we haven't given her *cause* to."

Lonnie had the grace to flush a little and look away. Glimmer nodded. Slowly. Bow glanced between the two and sighed, "We're moving out shortly. I had wanted to grab Adora buuut… I suppose they'll tell her up there. Or I tell her when she gets back I guess or…"

“Babe, what’s on your kind?” Glimmer smirked at her husband and shoulder nudged him, “You’re stalling.”

Bow chuckled, “Fair. So, Lonnie, I may have a way that will help us… get closer to Horde units. Which could help us with the plan. To save your friends, I mean. That sensor net… if we knew its disposition in more detail, we could move to mask our ships a little - specifically the former *Horde* ones. Can you help?”

Lonnie stared at him and frowned, “What do I owe you?”

“Well… it helps us help you. And it just plain old helps us. Isn’t that enough?” Bow shrugged, “Honestly, it would be super useful, make our jobs a *lot* easier.”

“I guess,” Lonnie shrugged, “But what, you gonna ram raid the station? Not gonna work.”

Glimmer shook her head, “One step at a time. We need your know how, you need us. None of us trust the other. Lets… start small, ok? And we’ll get your boys… somehow.”

There was a clang as the galley hatch swung in again and Adora stepped through. Her stance was tense, “Bow. Flotilla’s moving, I’m taking a shuttle to lead. Your crews need to get faster on that sensor net: Our timetable just got moved up,” she looked over at Lonnie, “How’s your EVA training?”

Lonnie blinked, suddenly tense again, “What?”

“I just got a really strange text-string message. From a *Commander Scorpia.* We're going for a walk…”

Chapter End Notes

As ever, thank you for your patience everyone. Writing has been a bit trickier the last couple of weeks, so getting to updates when I can, given IRL commitments!

As ever, I hope you enjoyed!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

An execution is planned, but a DARING RAID is in the works!

What can Adora and Lonnie do!

What is Catra's next step?

What is Adora's ENDGAME?!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Stars twinkled in the dark void, momentarily obscured by a small, barely-there vessel. Its hull was a dark grey, but it blended against the dust and gaseous background of the system, a fact reinforced by its lack of running lights. Its engines barely glowed as the vessel sculled from its jump-point exit. It had been on course for a good forty minutes. Its destination: a barely visible speck of rock amidst a collection of *other* rocks.Lights and distant static of comms traffic indicated that the target was a hive of activity.

In the cramped bridge of the freighter, fingers curled anxiously against the head-rest of the pilot's seat as a pair of anxious eyes stared out of the canopy. It was fruitless - the destination just a dot; the various instruments showing only minimal information given the low-power the ship was running on.

Huntara glanced over her shoulder from her seat at the helm and frowned at Lonnie's anxious face, "I can *hear* you sweatin'," she jutted her chin, "Go…. recheck your gear or somethin'."

The former Horde member glared at the bounty hunter, “Already checked.”

“Then what’s eating you up?”

Lonnie scoffed, “This whole plan. It’s… insane. It’s not going to work.”

“And yet here you are,” smirked Huntara. She turned back to her displays, “Crazy, huh?”

Lonnie just huffed, her fingers flexing against the headrest. Another voice chimed in from a terminal set at an angle in the small bridge, “Coming up on one point five kilo kilo marks.”

Huntara glanced over at the navigator cum comms operator and nodded, “Thanks G. That vector still good?”

The operator, a muscular woman with goat horns, glanced over and nodded briefly, “Yeah, we’re in the pipe still. Your HUD should still show the track.”

Lonnie nodded and blew out a breath, “That’s something. Scorpia isn’t the… trap kind. We can trust her. Question is just why is she helpin’?”

Huntara grunted, “A commander without any guile? How’s she lasted?”

The former-Horde officer glanced at Huntara and frowned, then shook her head. Her tight braids rustled briefly as she settled, “Know much about Horde command?”

“Enough. Did my time in there, decided freelancing was better. More *honest* ,” Huntara’s voice was low, bored, but had an edge, “Most high rankers slept with a knife under their bedroll. Infantry had it easier, but the officers got *nasty* at times. With each other at least. You don’t promote by shanking your one up in the middle of a fire fight, but in the barracks? Yeah politics all over the place.”

Lonnie blinked then chuckled, “Yeah, Scorp… the Commander, she’s not ruthless. But she’s effective. And no flies on her. By the book, reliable. And, well, she’s been out here in the boonies with us. I doubt she’d have lasted long in anywhere… really intense.”

“Maybe maybe not,” Huntara sighed, “She would probably get shoehorned into a nice cushy role no one would want.”

Silence fell for a moment, then the comms operator chimed in, “I know we’re… committed. But why are we trusting this if she’s *that* by the book and loyal?”

Lonnie's face screwed up, "She… Scorpia…" she shook her head, "Honestly, no idea. Maybe she doesn't want to see anyone *die* . Or play executioner. Honestly, don't know," she swallowed and looked out of the viewport once more, "It feels like a bad idea. I don't like it…"

"But gotta try, right?" Huntara sighed, "And mug here gets hauled along."

"You volunteered," came a slightly tinny voice from the hatch and the trio glanced nervously at the figure that ducked in. Adora was fully masked up, her eyes barely visible under the lenses of her helmet, "You going soft, Huntara?"

"Nah, just go where I'm told," she smirked at Adora over her shoulder, "And you needed a fancy pilot."

"I heard it was because Captain Mermista wouldn't let Seahawk help," G - the comms operator - interjected. Her laugh was nervous as she glanced at Adora again.

The Praetorian just grunted and tilted her head to look at the readouts, then looked at Lonnie. The former-Horde soldier tried to meet the other woman's gaze and managed a dry-throated, "What?"

"Anything else we need to know. These two raise a good point - can we really trust this?"

“You’re the one who hauled us off on this!” Lonnie hissed, “Comms came in and off we went!”

“You said I owed you, this was an opportunity. So, anything I should know?”

“No, Scorpia is… caring. This is genuine… but it’s risky as hell and…” Lonnie looked away, “And so much can go wrong. This whole plan is MADNESS!”

“What were you expecting?” Adora spoke, her voice cold, “Me to go in and kill half the station? In and out? How would *that* work out, hm?”

Lonnie didn’t meet the other woman’s eyes. She just shrugged. Adora hummed then jerked her thumb out of the hatch. Lonnie glared, then nodded and moved to push past Adora. The Praetorian stepped up to behind the helm and gave the readouts another once over. Huntara glanced up, “Bit harsh.”

“She wants to rescue those two. We’re rescuing them. Seems stupid to whine about the how of it.”

“You’ve never gone to bat for someone you care for, worried about how it’ll turn out?” Huntara scoffed. She flinched as the

headrest behind her creaked loudly. Adora let out a low, hissing breath, then gestured at the console.

"As planned, momentum launch for the pods. Keep at a distance, we'll need scoop pickup at a pretty precise angle."

Huntara looked back at the Praetorian, but couldn't read the woman. The voice, though, had a crack to it. She studied the blonde and frowned, "Lots can go wrong, Lonnie wasn't wrong about that."

"I know. But our options, given the time frame our friendly *commander* gave us. Not exactly a lot of time to come up with an in depth operation."

"So flinging a freighter and some scaled down pods is your go to?" Huntara scoffed, mildly amused, "This is your back-of-stims-pack planning? Man, your actual plans must've been hellah complicated."

Adora actually made a sound a little like a snort, which caused both Huntara and G to look at her with surprise. The Praetorian barely moved, but her voice was a little quieter when she spoke, "I was never the best planner. Relied on someone else for those," She looked thoughtful and mused, "Scorpia seems very… certain we'd succeed."

“Sounds like a bleeding heart, mother to her troops kind. The kind that get you killed because they don’t want to risk you, so you get outflanked,” Huntara shook her head, “She could’ve made this easier for us.”

“A sensor corridor all blacked out for us to approach, adjusted patrol lines and a precise timing isn’t good enough?” Adora actually chuckled, “We’ll make it work. Now, I best make sure our friendly traitor is all comfortable.”

The Praetorian ducked away down the narrow, industrial gangway that led into the bowels of the cramped hauler. She slid down a set of narrow stairs and through a few more passages until she reached the “cargo bay”. It was really little more than a room that led to docking clamp access to removable cargo pods. Lonnie stood, arms crossed, staring at the access hatch to one such “pod”.

“This is… insane.”

Adora scoffed, “You remember your zero g evac training?”

Lonnie hunched up and glared at Adora as she turned, “Yeah, but… this… this is so,” she clenched a fist and thrust her arms down along her sides, then gestured at her vacuum suit, “The chances are *tiny* ! Why *not* just…” she looked away, face angry. Adora stared at her impassively. Then she sighed.

“Like I said in the cockpit: you *want* me to kill the station? A repeat of before?”

Lonnie closed her eyes and shuddered, before her voice came out a hoarse whisper, “No. But… this can’t work.”

The room fell silent, save for the electric whirrr of the dim lights and the distant sound of a pump, circulating air. Adora studied Lonnie for a moment, then relaxed, “It will.”

“You can’t be sure!” Lonnie snapped, her gaze spinning to Adora, “And it’s all because of YOU. You put us here, you…”

“You chose,” Adora’s voice came out firm, but not… cold, “And you chose… to save those you care about. I can understand that. And Scorpia is choosing, too. And now *I’m* choosing. And I will save them.”

Lonnie sagged against the metal bulkhead and barked a manic laugh, “But why? You put us here, you… made…” she closed her eyes and blew out a snort, “Yeah, alright. We’re here. But I’m going to lose them. Then what?”

Adora moved closer, looming over the soldier, “I played you. Because that’s what I do. I’m a weapon, a killer, a person who uses everything in front of her to *survive* . But I have to. I have to survive. And you will learn how to. But today we’re going to save

your friends. I owe you that, for what you did. And because Kyle seems… nice.”

Lonnie looked up at the Praetorian. She seemed to be trying to hold onto her anger, but instead she looked tired, “Why me, though? Why am I here?”

“You want *others* to do this? To save you?” Adora cocked her head to one side and scoffed, “No, this way you clear up your messes. And we help you.Getting other people to do your dirty work? That’s the *Horde* speaking. You did the dirty work for other people, turned a blind eye. So. Here you are. After this, it’s up to you and your friends. Huntara made it. Others have. You can too.”

The blonde slapped at the hatch release for the pod next to them and Lonnie swallowed. She unhooked a helmet from a nearby locker shelf and pulled it on, sealing it in place, before she then manhandled a bulky air-tank onto her hip. She had a couple, highly compressed. She watched as Adora fastened a few to her own suit, then exhaled, “I guess…. I suppose it is a lot to expect,” she paused as she moved to duck into the hatchway, “Why do you do this? If you’re a weapon, why aren’t you just… taking the easy route?”

“Because… it isn’t easy,” Adora shrugged, “And it’s not my mission.” The Praetorian turned and stared at Lonnie, then tapped her helmet, “Remember, direct line of sight comms only when we’re out there. Minimal chance of discovery and intercept. *No* outbound comms. We have the timer, just follow the plan. Get the pod prepped, we need to be *fast* .”

Lonnie stared, conscious of the deflection, but then nodded and watched as Adora clambered into her own pod. She followed suit and settled in. It was a cramped fit, barely a pod at all, more like a hollowed out torpedo. A rudimentary console lit up, detailing angle and vector readings, as well as thruster options.

Her helmet comm crackled, " *5 minutes."*

She lay there in the dark, with only the glow of the console. Honestly, she hadn't really done much in zero-g beyond the basic training around ship evac survival. And that mostly consisted of "find a stellar body with gravity and landmarks".

This was *different.* . EVA walks and salvage had been a topic but she wasn't an engineer - she hadn't done *that* line of training. But at the brief meeting, she'd stuck her hand up. She knew she was being contrary, whining about how no one else was helping, but she was scared, worried and *angry* . None of this was fair.

But it was also her own damn fault, if she looked at it. And this was the only way to make things right. If it worked.

In her own pod, Adora stared sightlessly into the dark. She hadn't turned on her console and her *internal* functions she had managed to suppress, so her vision was clear. She drew in slow, careful breaths, mulling over the snap meeting they'd had before this: the arguments, the shouting from those present. How she had stepped up to take the lead. And how she'd shot down a particular suggestion from Angella.

"I will not sabotage the station."

"But Adora! This is a prime opportunity. They are opening a door for us," that had been Juliet, who was clearly irritated by her adamant stance.

"Yes. And if we repay the action by BLOWING UP segments of the station, then we kill ANY good will for the future."

"It's the HORDE!" Angella had huffed, "This could well be a trap anyway. And I don't feel comfortable…"

"It is not your decision, Angella," Adora had stated in a monotone, "And I will not draw attention to us with some… minor, performative flashy whizz bang BOOM crap."

That last had left the room slightly stunned, with Glimmer suppressing a grin. Adora hadn't quite been sure where it came from. But she also felt a hint of suspicion about where this request had actually come from.

And she was damned if she was going to take advantage of it to hurt others. She wasn't a weapon anymore. Not if she could help it.

"So you're refusing to help. And saving some… deserters," scoffed Juliet, but she had looked less than engaged with the topic.

"I'm saving people who helped us. And Lonnie asked. I may be able to do something while I'm there but I will not kill. Not under a request to co-operate. You're smarter than this, Angella. Juliet. You're hurting. But don't sink to their level. Don't ask me to do something THEY would ask of me."

That last line had rather killed the conversation. It had been Glimmer who'd approached after everyone had filed out, a shrewd look in her eye, "There's more here, isn't there?"

"Just… some stuff. And if we screw around it's going to make my mission later a lot harder."

"Getting Swift Wind back?"

Adora had stared at Glimmer for a long while, before she'd nodded, "Yeah. Totally. That."

"One minute," Huntara's voice over the comm drew Adora back out of her reverie. She shuffled and got comfortable. She counted down the seconds and powered up the small screen. The pod shuddered and lurched, the hiss of released clamps vibrating through its metal casing. She checked the vector and drew a slow breath, tracking her O2 levels.

She couldn’t see anything, save for sensor markers, transmitted by laser from Huntara’s tramp hauler - one of the smaller ships they’d managed to secure for this job. The plan itself was incredibly straightforward - simple, but with so many margins for error.

A sensor corridor, with no tracking, which would be sorted by Scorpia: this gave them an avenue of approach. They also had been given an airlock number and a very *very* vague view of patrol routes. There was a small, incredibly small, plas-glass view-port. She could see the partner pod to hers drifting on the same trajectory. Idly, she watched the sensor markers and counted down the distance. They were travelling fast, but low power - even with a sensor corridor, a cone of “unmonitored” space - likely a tenuous thing *anyway* , there was still the risk of the patrolling ships either spotting them OR not… and running into them.

She watched, impassively, as they sped by drifting scrap at the periphery of where the battle had been fought - the floating husks of shuttles and Horde drones. The wreck of a gunship drifted in and past her view. Distantly, above them, the wrecked hulk of the *Seagate* loomed, already covered in EVA techs; the sparks of welders and scrap mechs tearing hunks away was heartbreaking.

A pair of fighters screeched past, a couple of thousand metres away, but just visible by their engine trails. Adora held her breath but the pair just vanished behind the wreck, clearly buzzing the asteroids and wrecks as they patrolled. She pressed a couple of buttons and her pods adjusted with a thruster burn and slowed.She watched, nervously, as the other pod continued

forwards, then adjusted as well, sloppily. It wasn't on a precise course but they just needed an approximate area.

There was a faint *clunk* as something scraped along the side of her pod and Adora winced, chastising herself. Lonnie's pod moved around a cluster of floating scrap and then adjusted again, matching course with Adora.

They weren't heading for the station itself - that would be far too risky. And it'd mean they wouldn't be in the best position.

Instead, they drifted and slowed in the shadow of one of the smaller rocks. The two pods managed to brake to a stop and sculled towards the slowly spinning asteroid. Adora took a breath, symbolically, then popped the seal on her pod. No air escaped, having all been cycled into the pod's tanks - an atmospheric explosion would likely have been unpleasant and would have blasted her into the void. She watched as Lonnie emerged from her pod, gripping the side, her whole suit clearly vibrating. Adora stared at her and clicked her comms, "All ok?"

"This. Is. Awful," came Lonnie's shaky response.

EVA was tough for people. Adora imagined it must be similar to swimming in a deep lake: that sense of void below you, as you tried to ignore it, knowing that if you sank… that was it. Except here?

Here it was all around you. Up. Down. Everywhere.

She pushed the thought away, “Hold it together. Anchor the pod, secure your line. Now… we wait.”

—------

It never ceased to amaze Catra how the Military moved in ebbs and flows. Combat that had everyone sweating and screaming and which lasted seconds, followed by eons of interminable waiting and drifting. Mess hall meals and boring transit flights, interspersed with the insanity and terror of war.

She enjoyed certain parts of it. Or she thought she did. The feeling of watching a pirate vessel tear itself apart; the exhilaration of coming out of a fight alive; that sense of achievement, overcoming an opponent.

She’d felt it, felt the fear after that first tussle with Adora, what seemed ages ago. Then the sense of challenge, hunting the rebels. That was followed by the slow rise of victory as they beat their enemy back, as she’d captured Adora, lorded it over the other woman. All topped off with this victory, this prize, one to add to her growing list of achievements. Toppling Octavia, securing her rise in the esteem of the Horde Hierarchy.

And yet the ebb and flow was there - not just in the adrenaline, but in the lows and the moments of quiet between.

She stared at the data slate, trying to marshall her thoughts. Then a synthetic, sneering voice cut in, " *Your appointment is due, Captain."*

Catra grimaced and glared at the ceiling, "Back with us, huh? Couldn't decide to have a strike of conscience and just delete yourself?"

"I would not presume to do anything that could jeapordise your command, Captain. That would be irresponsible of me. SOmething you are familiar with, given your reckless nature. Ma'am."

Weaver had been restored, albeit with more safeguards. Entrapta's message had been distracted but on point: don't release the locks or she might try something new. And Catra did NOT need that with the imminent arrival of Hordak. The man had messaged again, adjusting his timeline for arrival *and* had also *oh so thoughtfully* provided a list of needed supplies, expectations and immediate plans.

The only relief had been a delay in his arrival. He had been angry in that message, but it seemed *other* things were happening beyond the system. Entrapta had reported a few preliminary vessels had arrived in orbit, some supply ships, but that was it. Hordak himself was likely going to be delay, albeit not by much. She'd got another day's grace at most.

Which meant she had time, but she'd scheduled the next duty to get it done before Hordak arrived with many *many* extra pairs of eyes.

"*You have an action to carry out, Captain. The crew are waiting* ."

With a hiss, Catra stood. She yanked on her officer's coat and planted the red cap onto her head. She stalk from her office, barely giving her myriad data pads and unfinished reports a glance. The corridors of the base were relatively deserted, as most of the off duty crew were gathered on the promenade, along with the "loyal" civilians who had been pushed back into running their businesses. A few of those had still been sorted and shipped out for re-education. Catra pushed those thoughts away - that wasn't a military concern. It wasn't *her* concern.

She emerged from the corridor into one of the more spacious corridors of the space station - the bar that was carved into the stone of the asteroid was at one side, the wider corridor here leading to the access lifts down to the main bay. But here was good enough for what needed to be done.

Two figures knelt in the middle of the wide corridor, with a pair of heavily armoured guards flanking them. Catra hadn't been to see them since the comms had come through - what good would it have done? She paused as she moved into the concourse and looked around. Soldiers and crew stood around, shoulder to shoulder, their eyes full of anger and uncertainty. Catra heaved a sigh - this had to happen one way or another. She glanced to her side as her XO approached. Scorpia was due to move out with the *Vengeance* soon but this duty had to be done first.

The Captain and current commander of the local Imperial Horde forces took Scorpia's proffered data slate. She tapped the microphone atop it and read from the sheet, "Ensign Kyle Del. Lieutenant Rogelio Werr. You are charged with crime against the Imperial Navy and His Imperial Majesty, violating the code of conduct of the Imperial Officer code and sedition and mutiny, under sections 2.5 and 3.7 of said code. The charges include: Mutiny; conspiracy to mutiny; conspiracy to sabotage; sabotage; assisting the enemy in times of war; aiding the foe in active combat situations; endangerment of your crew; endangerment of your vessel; sharing military secrets; violation of the official secrets and communications codes; conspiracy to murder; manslaughter; destruction of Imperial property…." she paused and glared at the pair, "Under these serious charges, your right to a courts martial have been waived and summary judgement has been authorised by Governor Hordak of the Sector. I am in full agreement with these charges."

"You did the same!" Kyle managed, only to be cuffed around the ear by a guard. He sprawled to the ground and Rogelio moved to help, only to be restrained by the other soldier. Catra scoffed.

"I was detained. I escaped. I succeeded and then *presented myself* to the proper authorities, when an illegal order was given," Catra sneered, "You tried to actively harm and kill your fellows during an active combat situation. All to protect yourselves. You risked everyone here sucking vacuum".

The crowd rumbled, angrily. Catra had to maintain control. Kyle was running his mouth and the circumstances *could* be seen as similar - except fundamentally, she had *won* . But that was a level

of nuance that a mob didn't care about and she had to channel that. Rogelio glared at her and rumbled, *"This is… an atrocity."*

"You signed the regulations. You took the Emperor's credit chit. And you chose to risk everyone here. EVERYONE." Catra leaned forwards, "I should put a round in your skulls and leave your corpses here so everyone can kick them…" she swallowed, feeling the bile rising - she felt the anger at their actions, yes, but she….

She understood it.

…but she also didn't *want* to kill them.

Catra let out a breath through her nose, her glare focused on the pair. Then she sneered, "But that;d be too quick. People sucked vacuum, people nearly got blown into the void. So I think that… that is a better end. Maybe you'll learn a lesson before the end. The sentence for your crimes is *death* . By asphyxiation in the vacuum of space. But I'm going to make you really *see* what you nearly caused. Scorpia. Their suits."

Scorpia nodded stiffly and a pair of techs stepped forward. With much cursing, the pair were manhandled into a very rudimentary set of civilian EVA suits - thin, patched and clearly not very well insulated. Oxygen containers with flashing red indicators were strapped to their belts. Rogelio stared down, then up at Catra, " *What…what?"*

“You will be ejected from the airlock, with enough air to drift and float. Consigned to the void, no grave, no memorial. No ship here will offer you sanctuary, or harbour. You risked us in the black, now we send you to it. We’re going to make you… walk the plank.”

A cheer roused from the mob of soldiers - comrades who, under other circumstances, may have understood why they’d done what they did. But right now, they were a hair's breadth away from gutting these two.

And if she let that happen, it set a precedent.

She followed as the pair were marched towards one of the more public docking locks. She watched, impassive as the pair were shoved in. Catra smirked, “One small mercy. I’ll let you die together. Provided you can hold on to each other. It’s more than you gave anyone else.”

She stepped forwards waving away one of the guards and stared at the two glaring former-Horde soldiers. She swallowed, her eyes damp as she tapped in the code that sealed the airlock. A moment later, she stepped up the viewport and made eye contact with the pair of them. Then she stepped back and scoffed, waving at Scorpia, who moved to the viewport. The XO coughed and began to read off the various charges in more detail into the comm. Catra folded her arms, looking bored, then, as Scorpia wound down, keyed in the release for the airlock, before she pushed the emergency button.

The outer door flashed open, blasting the pair out explosively as the atmosphere was yanked away. The two tumbled out, violently, vanishing away into the black. Scorpai stared through the porthole. Catra leaned on the console, her face stoic, her feral grin held in place like a rictus. She drew several hard breaths, then turned, back straight, eyes cold, to the few who had managed to squeeze into the corridor. She spoke cooly into the data-pad microphone, "The sentence has been carried out. Let it be known I will not tolerate treachery. No one will let you down, no one will risk your security. Not on… on my watch. All quarters, back to duties."

She watched the crew deflate and disperse. She imagined the scene would be repeated across the station - the bloodlust denied, without a more visceral execution - but also the sense of fear the idea of being spaced would also bring. Her level of dismissiveness would undoubtedly cause *more* whisperings. She shook her head, "Commander I… I will be in my office if you need me. Report on the *Vengeance's* progress once you depart."

Catra glanced briefly back at the airlock and sagged. She wondered if miracles could happen. The pair had put others at risk.

But could she blame them? They'd done more than she had… but she crushed that thought and any other orbiting hopes. Instead she gave Scorpia a nod and headed back towards her current office, mind locking down in preparation for Hordak's arrival.

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Timing was vital. One wrong move, one mis-timed grasp and either they'd be spotted or they'd be sent tumbling away into the black with no hope of rescue. The Horde would be *very* unlikely to help. And Huntara wasn't in a position to dive in and help, not in her little skiff.

In the time they were waiting Adora hadn't been idle, of course. She'd already mapped out some potential vectors to intercept, given the information provided by their surprise benefactor in this. But she'd also spent time setting up a nice little gadget on the rock they were moored to: A small antenna device, which she'd had stored in the pod.

Very weak, it wouldn't easily transmit. But she'd pointed it at the main comm tower for the base and was currently downloading a record of transmissions and logs of incoming traffic. It'd likely mostly be junk on patrols, but there could be at least updates on plans and destinations for ships - enough for the rebels to hide and avoid right now.

Lonnie's comm chirped in her ear, implying the woman was looking at her, trying to get her attention. Adora looked up and the other woman spoke, " *Wide band transmission from the base…"*

Adora nodded and switched her radio channel over. She winced slightly as Catra's voice came over the comms. She sat, silently, as she listened to her former friend talk, running through the charges, until a small, sad smile creased her face. Adora closed her eyes and tensed her jaw and slowly shook her head.

She heard the pain. How could she not? Or was she hoping, praying it was there? That Catra wasn't fully involved, fully on board with the Empire?

She shook herself and straightened - now more sure of her mission. Adora glanced at Lonnie, then looked down at her pod. She tugged at the line she had attached to it, and the winch inside. This was going to be risky as all hell. She watched the side of the base - huge, even at their distance of several kilometres.

And then she saw it - a blast from the side - air vapour and a shift in debris. She looked at Lonnie, "Go. Go. Go."

The pair pushed up and off. Adora noted the frigates were at a further distance, way beyond the asteroids - too far to detect or monitor. The Destroyer was on the far side of the station, being resupplied most likely. The fighters were steering clear, doing a perimeter patrol. The only dangers were debris.

And the problem of the pair going in divergent directions.

Which they were. She watched as the smaller of the pair tumbled and bounced off a drifting piece of metal. She cursed as she saw a puff of white, indicating a suit breach - her eyes keen in the void-dark. Lonnie was bee-lining for the other figure, which was tumbling more slowly, using their oxygen to try to power tiny, near useless thrusters.

They were hundreds, near thousands, of metres away. Relying on vision and faint *very faint* suit beacons. Which were barely there in the suits of the two condemned men.

Adora powered forwards, the hiss of her jets loud in the silence of her helmet. She angled and had to weave around debris, conscious of her line. The small figure had drifted and hit a slab of broken-off hull, which he slid along, flailing and spinning. Her radio crackled with Lonnie's voice, " *I… I have Rogelio. He… he's not breathing, he's used his O2. Returning to pod. Where's Kyle… Where's Kyle?"*

Adora couldn't turn her head to beam line-of-sight comms back to Lonnie, who was clearly in a state of mild panic. She hoped the woman wouldn't start looking all over and sending random comms out. Last thing they needed was for one of the fighters to pick that up and come looking.

Adora hauled to a stop and cursed, realising her line had tangled. She made a split second decision.

She unclipped the line and boosted off at an angle. She dove at a slowly spinning piece of hull, a bar, really, then shoved off it to dive at another hulk of metal. She bounced off that, preserving her precious O2, then tumbled into the spinning form of Kyle.

The pair tumbled further, out of control until Adora managed to settle their spin into a more regular dizzy yet level turn. Kyle was limp and she could see no fog in his helmet. Adora checked her levels and clucked her tongue. She managed to orient herself as

they spun and hit a burst to arrest their tumble. Slowly, they drifted, still on a different trajectory. WIth another spurt of air, Adora punted them towards the hulk of the *Seagate* . She hugged Kyle to her and groaned as they hit the bulkhead *hard* .

They were a good couple of kilometres away from the pod now. More than that - maybe a dozen? Adora kept her breathing stead, then unlatched one of her oxygen tubes and fastened it to Kyle's input. She winced as she saw his suit inflate a tiny bit as air fed in, before it bled out of a few small tears. However Kyle seemed to twitch.

Adora unhooked her valve - best to save it - then froze as a drone hovered up nearby. The bulbous, yellow thing settled against the bulkhead and began to carve away with a plasma torch. Adora exhaled, realising the thing wasn't even registering them. She studied the drone, then grinned. Reaching out, she grappled the thing, rapidly letting her Praetorian suit run a brief override. She held onto Kyle as the drone sped away from the hulk, towing the two of them. She chuckled slightly as she saw a manned EVA cutting suit drift around the hull of the *Seagate,* inspecting the spot they'd just vacated - timing was *everything* and they'd gotten lucky.

After a few dozen metres, Adora released the drone and let the momentum take them forward. The small bot spun in space, then jetted back to its original role - no doubt the techs would find its behaviour odd… but not too much. It was still doing its job, after all.

The pair shot through space, silently. Adora spotted her drifting line, still tangled in debris: given their tumbled trajectory she was

honestly shocked she had managed to keep track of it - but ruefully admitted to herself it was likely due to her *augmentations* .

She arrested their approach with some more thrusts - she had no desire to impact a wire cable in space *at speed* . She managed to haul the cable and clipped herself back in, then began to pull herself and Kyle back towards the pod. She paused to reattached her breathing tube to Kyle's suit, then yanked her way down the cable, hauling him with her.

It was nerve wracking, the only sound her breathing and the ragged twitching of the man she was pulling. She saw the pods enlarge as they drew closer and saw Lonnie securing Rogelio in her pod. The man was flailing, clearly trying to get away, to help. Adora keyed her helmet comm and stared at Lonnie, "Kyle Secured. Suit breached. Prep the pod. Radio silence."

Lonnie turned, her body floating, as she looked wildly around, finally settling on Adora. The woman then jetted to ADora's pod and began to pull out additional hoses and set up smaller tanks. Adora hauled Kyle down and checked his face plate - the man's face was blue, with frost forming. Not good. Cursing, Adora, manhandled him into the pod. She shoved Lonnie back, ignoring the woman's gesticulating, as she hauled an emergency kit from the pod itself - the thing was a rudimentary escape vehicle, so had *some* supplies. Notably a suit sealing kit. She tore into it and began to secure the patches she could see. It was quick work, while Lonnie finally began to move and secure Kyle in place, attaching more hoses. The man jerked, suddenly, as the final seal went in place. His eyes shot open and he stared up at Adora. Then he began to flail, fighting. Adora grappled him as he tried to kick her away. Then he froze as Lonnie moved in and grasped his

shoulders, shaking her head. Kyle froze, staring at her, then looked at Adora. He relaxed and blinked, then… he fainted. Lonnie flailed but Adora shoved her gently away, pointing to Rogelio.

Eventually, the two men were secured. Lonnie fussed a little more, then pulled herself back to Rogelio, where she squeezed into the pod with him. Adora shunted Kyle to one side and settled into the pod with him.

This next part was going to be… difficult. Carefully, she keyed the thrusters and moved away. The two pods angled away, then pointed at a heading. There was a brief flash as their rudimentary engines fired. Before, they'd had the momentum of their launching ship. This time, they had thrusters only.

She grimaced at the pod's O2 levels and the thrust left. She grimaced even more as she saw a few fighters angling off their designated, expected patrol route, then sighed as they adjusted back on course.

Adora settled down, while Kyle shifted, clearly awkward. Adora didn't care - plenty of time for chats later. The two pods drifted, silently. Until Huntara's faint voice cracked over the comm, *"Anyone order a cab…?"*

There was a clunk and then a hiss as her pod attached. It opened and Adora scrambled out first, turning to pull a shivering, dazed Kyle free. Opposite, across the cramped bay, Lonnie was hauling a coughing Rogelio free of their pod, the reptile clearly suffering

from his time in the cold, his body having likely shed far too much warmth.

Adora stepped back as Kyle flailed, the man hauling his hamlet free to draw out deep, gulping lungfulls. He looked up at her, confusion and irritation on his face, until his frantic gaze found Lonnie and Rogelio. Then he staggered across the bay and launched himself at the pair. The trio sagged to the decking, all talking at once, lost in an embrace.

For the first time in a while Adora felt invisible and unseen once more. And this time it brought a strange sense of awkwardness. She watched the trio for another short moment, then sighed and turned away, stalking out of the bay and up towards the cockpit.

Huntara turned in her seat and grinned, "Job well done. Who knew Praetorians could do search and rescue, huh?" the bounty hunter paused as Adora stood, impassively, "Y'know, I preferred it when you didn't wear the mask, blondie. I could at least tell if your were pissed."

Adora shrugged, "Mission complete. Results satisfactory. Onto the next."

"Uh huh," Huntara scoffed, "And how long? How many more?" She sounded cynical. Adora actually chuckled.

“Not long… not long at all,” Adora stared out of the cockpit canopy, which showed the distant speck of the starbase, its occupants mostly unknowing of the daring rescue that had just occurred. Adora;’s smile was hidden by the mask,

She hoped it wouldn’t be too many more. She thought about the three in the hold for the barest moment. Envy tugged at her heart. And also something else, something she’d held back in her chest, too scared to think on, despite it driving her for so long.

Hope.

Chapter End Notes

Hey gang!

Yeah, Adora's getting NICE FEELINGS!

A bit of some actual action that isn't action.

We'll close this one off fairly soon! Cause Adora has a plan soon, and we have HORDAK inbound.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> Everything is going swimmingly. Catra deals with her worries, Adora contemplates her plans and a new face stirs the pot.

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for your patience all - an update before we wrap up this little chapter in the series!

It was strange watching people cheer for the death of comrades. The jeers, the yells, the shouts. Some of it even sounded genuine. Which was chilling. The rest sounded like those crowds that Catra had seen cheering the military parades of the Capital. All that energy, that *force* , that fervour - and yet it felt an illusion, almost a performance. People psyching themselves up otherwise the ever present eyes would fall on them.

And in all of this, none of them really looked at Catra. Despite cheering, no one turned to nod at her, or even offer a grim smile. It was interesting. No *"it had to be done* ."

Even if what she'd done was monstrous in the extreme.

Catra managed to keep it together as she trudged through the corridors, her cap brim low, her tail lashing from side to side. She was stoic, rigid, but her insides churned with bile. Her thoughts swam with colours and fears and she only drew herself up short when she realised she'd entered the command centre. Eyes stared at her. Eyes full of fear and… maybe respect? Everyone knew how

the Horde operated - but not many had *seen* an actual execution up close. Not many had *known* traitors.

And even knowing, hoping, that what had happened *hadn't* happened, it was still something awful. And something Catra had willingly signed up for.

But it was abstract; dumb rules that we'd never have to follow .

Her gaze swept the room, followed by a curt nod, before she stalked into the ready room. As the door slid shut, she managed to make it to the sink - the base's prior commander had seen fit to install a rudimentary bathroom to their own office. Clearly not military.

But useful when you wanted to throw up.

Catra held the sink edges and drew ragged breaths, then reached unsteadily for her cap. She tossed it back into the office then hunched over again. She shook and wiped at her mouth before she met her reflection's gaze.

"You made your choices. Now live with it," she admonished herself, weakly. And yet she felt she heard it in someone *else's* voice.

Would she have to do this again? Would she have the option of *maybe* saving the next traitor, the next one who broke ranks? Or would she be boxed in? Wasn't she already?

A tentative knock at the door drew her attention and she rinsed out the sink, before she splashed water onto her face, patting her fur dry. With a shake, she stalked back and took a seat at her desk. She yanked a data pad towards her and propped her chin on her hand, resting her elbow on her chair's arm, to hide the shaking, "Come!"

The door hissed open and Scorpia stepped inside. She paused a moment and the door slid shut with a final click. The Commander frowned and bit her lip, "Ma'am?"

Catra's eyes flicked up from the data pad and regarded Scorpia, "Something amiss, Commander?"

"I… wanted… hooo boy, are, are you ok, Wildcat?"

Catra's jaw tensed and she licked her lips, "Why wouldn't I be? I had to perform an unsavoury but necessary task," her throat bobbed and her ears flicked down for the barest moment.

"Uhm, I know it's against protocol but… um…" Scorpia huffed, then moved, quickly, around the desk. Catra's eyes widened in shock as the burly woman scooped her out of the plush office chair and crushed the Captain to her in a hug. Catra hissed in

shock and scrabbled against her second in command, before she flopped, limp in the stronger woman's grip. Her claws latched into Scorpia's pincers and flexed.

"Pu…put me down," she hissed, hoarsely. Scorpia huffed and squeezed, then rocked.

"Ma'am…" her own voice was quiet, pained. Catra squeezed her eyes shut and sagged. She didn't hug Scorpia back, rather she just let the big woman have the moment. And, frankly, the proximity, the touch - it helped. It wasn't *quite* what she wanted, but that she only really contemplated in her bunk, in the dark, in half asleep fugue moments.

The pair stood, silent, Catra's hands flexing but not scratching as she semi-kneaded Scorpia's carapaced claw. After what seemed an age, Scorpia carefully set Catra back down and the feline office stumbled back into her seat. She coughed and nodded quickly, "Uh… yeah. So. Um… that task…"

Scorpia nodded in return and stepped back around to the front of the desk, assuming an *at ease* pose, "No reports. I was, um, about to take the *Vengeance* out for a shakedown. And, um, to… cover a sensor gap we apparently had."

Catra stared at Scorpia and let a small breath out of her nose. The taller woman stiffened, a worried look on her face for a moment, before Catra asked,"A sensor gap?"

"Yes, only a small corridor. But, um, we'll make sure it's fully covered."

"Any chance anything in that gap could have… snuck in, picked up or… stolen something?"

"Only if they were forewarned, ma'am. And since we exited the traitors… that's unlikely."

"And we know that… none of our ships are moving to retrieve the bodies?" Catra stared at Scorpia, practically straining in her seat. The Scorponi woman met her gaze and her mouth quirked into a frown, which loosened the tension in Catra's gut minutely.

"None of ours are, ma'am. Orders are orders. Do… do you want us to retrieve their bodies?"

"No. As I said. Consigned to the dark. Very well, carry on."

Scorpia watched Catra and seemed to relax a little, as if she had just confirmed something. She smiled a little, "I'll ensure someone gets you a coffee, ma'am, before I go."

The door hissed shut, after Scorpia left and the room felt a little less oppressive. It wasn't a guarantee, but if Catra knew her old friend (and especially with that friend's new approaches) then she

was fairly sure that things had panned out. And she was grateful that Scorpia was able to see hints dropped from a mile off.

She tried to refocus on the reports but there was only so much you could take in around fuel distribution and ammunition requisitions; scouting reports were barely coming in, given the rapidity of the changes and, really, the seizure of the fueling stations and minor mining rigs was a slow task. She was keen to avoid stretching what forces she had too thin. And, anyway, the main focus were those damn ruins and that weird ship Adora had kindly left behind.

Catra felt a tinge of guilt at that, adding to her already tense sense of self. Under all her bravado and drive, there was that sliver of poison, than burning echo in her head that maybe, probably, Adora had been on the right track all those years ago.

But to turn around now felt like it'd prove that Catra had *wasted* time. Better to be on the top of the pile, safe there, than under it.

She flinched as she heard something crack and blinked in surprise, as she saw she'd managed to put a claw through the data-pad's screen. With a slow exhale, she placed the now-busted computer back onto her desk and leaned back. A knock at the door roused her before she could slip into more introspection. WIth a bark of " *Enter* ," the door slid open to reveal one of the techs manning the stations in the command centre.

"Ma'am priority message," the tech looked exceedingly nervous. Catra frowned and slowly stood up.

“And? What is it?”

“Governor Hordak. His ship, the, uh… *Loyal Light* … has just dropped from hyperspace at the system edge. He says to, um… expect him imminently.”

Catra swallowed and nodded, “All hands to ready stations, get word to Commander Scorpia to have the *Vengeance* and its escorts move to rendezvous with the Governor’s ship and to provide an honour guard. We need docking bays cleared and prepped if they aren’t already.”

“Yes ma’am,” the tech saluted, then scurried away. Catra blew out a breath, then ran a hand through her hair.

“Crap.”

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Adora lounged in the co-pilot’s chair gaze unfocused as she stared into the black beyond. The Cloud nimbus of the broken planetoid was coming into view, staining the dark with lurid emerald and greys - the decaying corpse of the planet a sinister warning of *something* . It was a distant thing, still, like a bleeding eye in the black.

Huntara was flicking her gaze between various readouts before she glanced across at the blonde mercenary, "Good going back there, blondie."

Adora smiled under her mask and nodded slowly, "A successful mission. Always a good sign."

"Look at you, heart and soul of the party," Huntara snickered, "Hell of a thing, putting your life on the line for… those sort."

Adora let her eyes flick to the pilot, "Oh? And what would those sort be?"

The purple warrior huffed, "I guess I should say *my* sort. Old habits, y'know? Can't help but feel a bit sore at mutineers. I was a deserter and, well…" she idly fiddled with a control, switching one of the green text displays between various readouts, before she let out a sigh, "I'd like to think my actions didn't hurt none of my sisters in arms, y'know? These guys well… actively sabotaging a ship during an active battle?"

The blonde hummed to herself and nodded, "Mainly because I forced them. They did what they did… because I said I'd hurt them if they didn't. So, they showed loyalty," her voice was dispassionate, detached. Huntara glanced at her and frowned.

"Would you?" she asked.

Adora tilted her head and shrugged, "Not then, no. But I may have if it was desperate. And then would have killed them if they'd betrayed us. But now… now we're square."

"You're cold."

"It's been said," Adora leaned out of the chair and shook her head, "We're all traitors. The military said to trust the person next to you… but so much of the advancement in the Horde is about getting an advantage. Getting a good post, getting the right command. And soldiers? All of them want to be a Corporal, or Force Captain. The only time there's any real loyalty is when the blaster bolts are flying. Those three? I wouldn't trust them with my back. But they'd die for each other. We ran away for ourselves, really. They did it for each other."

Huntara flinched as Adora barked out a laugh, "You think that's funny?"

"Isn't it? And some people are *still* loyal to the Empire, even when it grinds and grinds and grinds things into dust," Adora let out a breath, her cold voice still as detached as before, "Doesn't matter. We did something… decent. And now Lonnie can help me."

"That's what I figured," Huntara. She smiled wanly, "You aren't wrong, y'know. I loved it… when it was good. But those days when things chafed and you didn't know who to trust, well, that just eats at you. And if I look at myself… I probably didn't exactly make a clean break. So I can't judge them. But being a star-farer,

knowing you have people who nearly voided their own is… difficult. But I don't think that they're… bad?"

"Is that why you're asking?" Adora sounded genuinely curious. Huntara shrugged.

"I guess. I know there's a deal here but even for that, this isn't small. But you did something good. And I have no idea how to read you, blondie. What makes you tick. I like knowing that. You… you scare the void outta me."

"Thanks."

"Wasn't a compliment."

Adora just shrugged. Before their rambling conversation could continue the comms tech, G, gasped, "Huntara, we need to adjust course."

The pilot stiffened and looked back to the other woman, "Ok, new heading?"

Under her visor, Adora smiled - Huntara was a pro. No exasperated demands, no *what, why?* - just straight up trust. It was strange to see. She saw it with the three in the hold - clearly professional but with a loyalty that overrode everything else.

Huntara had it for those she chose. Adora commanded *something* like it… but it was a shadow thing.

G scanned over her monitors, "Sending to your console. By the stars, that isn't good."

The blonde frowned, "What is it?"

Huntara adjusted their course, angling to a different approach. G glanced over at Adora, worry etched on her face, "New patrol signatures. We had a comm from the command net, bouncing off one of the Horde comm buoys - new ships just arrived. The *Vengeance* is en route, with a flotilla."

The Praetorian stood and moved to stand next to the comm-terminal, "What is it saying?"

"It's… it's a fleet. Not a patrol fleet. I mean it's a *fleet* . Numbers aren't precise but it looks like a command carrier and its escorts. No battleships but enough cruisers and frigates… that it's bad news."

Adora stared at the scrolling text and intercepted orders. She shook her head, then holler down into the cargo hold, "Lonnie!"

There was a clatter and scramble as the woman emerged, her face full of defiance and fear, "What?"

The blonde placed a hand on the hatch frame and glanced between the comm terminal and Lonnie, “Massive fleet, just arrived in system. Any ideas?”

The former-Horde officer blinked at Adora’s terse but curious tone. Her brow furrowed and she cursed, “Crap, it’s gotta be the governor. I don’t know much, only know we were expecting maybe an envoy, or something, to help with research. Catra kept a lot of it to the senior officers. I knew we might get like an inspection visit. A fleet?”

Adora nodded slowly, “A battlegroup at least. Command carrier, full escort detail and… a support fleet.”

“It’s gotta be that freaky ship of yours. And the ruins,” Lonnie sighed. She looked uncomfortable, “No way we’re gonna get it back now.”

“Where is Swift Wind?”

Lonnie blinked, “Oh yeah, that’s its name. Weird..” she leaned back as Adora’s gaze pierced her, “Uh, we… we surveyed a few planets. There’s a survey base, with a fully integrated research bay and hangar set up… on the ice planet. It’s where we operated from before uh, before we…”

"Before you took the asteroid…" Adora nodded slowly, "So he hasn't been shipped out of the system yet. Maybe that's why they have a carrier. Full security. They must know," Adora mumbled to herself, "Does *Catra* know?"

"Look, Adora, you… you saved the boys. And me. And, yeah you got us here but… we're out of the Horde. So maybe you should too? Just… just go? Take everyone, get outta here. There's other systems, other places."

Lonnie looked awkward, as if the idea of pleading was uncomfortable for her. Even if it was her trying to find a compromise. Adora looked at her and shook her head, "I can't do that. Can you imagine if every Horde ship could do what mine could? If that power was scaled up, deployed a thousand times over? There'd be nowhere safe. Soldiers given the power to carve ships apart, single handed? No…. no."

Adora pushed off of the bulkhead and turned to Huntara. The mercenary shook her head, "We need to get back to HQ, refit. And refuel. I'm not flying to *another* Horde base blind."

"You won't have to," Adora crossed her arms, "I just need to get into orbit."

Lonnie shook her head, "There's frigates *always* on station. Patrol flights. RADAR, LADAR, thermal. Entrapta has that place wired so microbes need freakin' papers to get in."

Adora slowly turned to regard Lonnie, “Entrapta?”

“Our… the Horde chief engineer. She’s, like, a super genius. Even had our Weaver shackled. Still does, I think.”

The Praetorian nodded slowly, “Good to know. Ok. Huntara, get us back to Command. We need to move *fast* ,” She looked back at G’s terminal and shivered, “I have a really… really bad feeling about this.”

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A battlefleet was, frankly, an awe inspiring sight. Catra had seen two of them - once during training, when the cadets were given a shakedown tour during an active conflict; then once more when she’d commissioned and taken her first vessel out from the Home fleet. The myriad frigates and cruisers, along with the escort destroyers, were intimidating on their own, but the command carrier was something else.

It wasn’t intended to have its own major firepower, although it could slug it out quite well with many other smaller ships-of-the-line. Its strength lay in the divisions of troops, fighters and bombers it could bring to bear.

The thing was blocky, not sleek like some of the Horde cruisers or scout frigates; the carrier looked like several containers, smoothed at the corners, with command towers and bulky turrets, all

protecting the various hard-point hangers and launch bays. It looked like a castle, really, but stretched out. It dwarfed the destroyers, being twice their size. She'd knew battleships matched the carriers in size, but were purely engines of destruction. And the rare dreadnaughts that the EMpire had were, basically, battle enders, only deployed at the Emperor's whim.

A command carrier in a system usually meant the end of hostilities, just from sheer force projection. To a hosting commander, it was either a welcome relief, or a horrifying reminder that they'd failed.

Catra wondered where she fell in that spectrum, even with what had happened.

She'd watched as the fleet had arrived, just hours after she'd sent two men into the void. The strange pomp and ceremony, combined with mundanity of the preparations, alongside such a cruel act had her head in a spin. The bile had gone down as she'd focused on the scrolling list of tasks - her command ran itself for the most part; people had their orders, knew what was needed of them. All she now needed to do was stand here, in the main hangar, awaiting Hordak's shuttle.

She'd positioned marines in honour guard positions. They wore combat armour polished and buffed as best they could - no one really brought *parade* finery into active combat zones, after all.

She'd had a chance to look over the hangars in more detail and this one was very much an *industrial* environment - landing pads

among rocks in a broad cavern; fuel silos; additional tunnels that led to ancillary cargo bays and mineral storage areas. It didn't scream *resistance headquarters* . It just shouted *mining base* really loudly.

A civilian home, a place to try to live. And now it had corridors splattered with blood and a morgue of cooling corpses. The recovery was ongoing in the vacuum outside, as rebel ships were towed into scrap-fields for processing.

Catra preferred combat; preferred the cut and thrust of a fight. Your blood pumping, the only thing that mattered was the thrill of live-or-die. It was the quiet moments afterwards where she struggled. In space, it was easier - dust and scrap and blossoming flame gave distance to that death, to consequence. One ship down, move to the next. No time to think.

But this? This fighting corridor to corridor, seeing a face from the past, feeling their breath after so long?

Watching as she sent people she tentatively considered… comrades… to their deaths (Or, she hoped, their salvation?) What did it really say for her?

" *Captain. Shuttle on deck. I hope you are ready."*

Weaver's voice was snide, cloying as ever. The AI seemed to be on an even keel again, Catra wasn't completely sure - that was

another variable she'd have to juggle with this Governor. She ignored the AI and watched as a sleek, white shuttle slid into the hangar, banking in the cavernous space. It was dagger-like, a white blade of a ship. The vessel extended spindly landing legs from its smooth frame. Excess steam vented from the landing gear and a ramp descended - the hull seemed to split apart to allow the gantry to descend out from the ship's belly.

First to exit were a pair of Shock-Troopers. Her own troops were hardened marines, but these were the Storm Troopers - their armour looked bulky and odd - conical helmets that sealed onto their power armour made them look almost commercial or ungainly. But they moved with slow, steady grace. The pair took up flanking positions at the base of the ramp and Catra watched as a tall, thin man exited the vessel.

He wore robes of dark blue, over what looked like stylised combat armour - hardly official wear for some toady governor. His features were pale and gaunt, something the holo-vids hadn't quite conveyed. And his solid red eyes seemed to stare at everything, taking it all in.

He strode along the gangway from the landing pad and paused in front of Catra, his hands clasped behind him. The man's stare was cold, verging on a bored sneer. Catra swallowed and flashed a salute, "Welcome, Governor Hordak. The base is ready for your inspection. We are in the process of securing and repairing damage, but…"

"Captain Catra…" his voice was slow, deliberate, and carried that affected accent of the central systems - all poise and condescension. He looked around at the space with a

contemptuous sneer, "I am sure you have things *in hand* with regard to this backwater. I want a full debrief."

"Sir," Catra spun and fell in step with the man as he strode past the honour guard, who braced in salute. He nodded an acknowledgement and continued on into the bowels of the base.

It was, perhaps, the oddest debrief she'd ever conducted - the man was silent, listening as she ran through the minutiae of their buildup and final assault. She described the defences offered and how they'd circumvented them, along with the challenges and the minimised casualties. She watched the strange man as he idly viewed various parts of the base, until they reached the promenade. Like most of the base, it was all within the rock - corridors and carved out spaces. The Governor regarded the crude signs and rudimentary composition of the place, then scoffed.

"All that effort, for this? I will commend you, Captain, in that you took a ball of rock with so few losses."

Catra wasn't sure if she was being mocked and she couldn't help the snarl that sprang forth, "By Horde doctrine, anything up to a third would have been acceptable."

She froze as Hordak turned and glared at her. Then he smiled, thinly, "Quite so. So you are ahead. But do not think that gives you… leeway. This was a respectable achievement, Captain. Rebellion scattered, a stronghold secured. However… you did not

capture their leadership. An enemy fleeing is an enemy to be dealt with down the line - a challenge."

Catra winced at the rebuke, "They were civilians, sir. We broke their combat arm, but given the forces I had, this guaranteed securing a defensible asset and resulted in us absolutely decimating their capabilities. They have *no where* to go. We have the planets monitored, we have the system traffic being staked out."

Hordak regarded her cooly and nodded, "We shall see. I will admit I am impressed. Of all the commanders who report to me, none have managed to accomplish such a feat with even three times the resources allocated. I fully expected you to fail, to be another *willful* Captain that would self-resolve. And yet, here you stand."

Catra was aware of the pair of Storm Troopers that stood behind her. She stared up at Hordak, not breaking eye contact. He smirked down at her then nodded slowly. She huffed, "So, what are your *orders* , sir?"

His smirk widened, "Simply that you continue on. I will be frank with you, Captain: competence is a rare resource in the military. I have no time for lickspittles and toadies. Continue to secure the sector. And now, while this is *very quaint* , I have something else I wish to see."

Catra exhaled in relief. She'd fully expected to have a blast bolt in the back of her head. She continued on alongside the Governor, "Will you be locating your command here, sir?"

“No. It is static. Remote. I am content for you to base yourself here. You have two objectives: secure the sector, by any means. And ensure that my operations are undisturbed.”

“That… is doable, sir.”

“ *Doable* ?” Hordak sneered. He stopped and regarded her, “I expect more than that, Catra. My fleet will be securing the research station. And I will require a full breakdown of your sensor sweeps of the Planetoid.”

“The… broken planet, sir?”

“Yes. You didn’t think I was just here for a single vessel, did you?” his sneer was contemptuous, “Or for your simplistic little war? No, there is a prize here. I recognise ambition, Catra. It is a valuable trait… if tempered. You know your limits, so far. You have not overstepped *too* much. And you have… delivered. Your methods show you are effective. But I am concerned you are *sentimental* over these yokels. The Empire does not survive on mercy - it is maintained by rigorous and *consistent* application of the law. Ensure this is performed here. I expect your captives to be shipped out to the penal colonies and any further resistance to be crushed. This does not appear to be beyond your… capabilities.”

Catra nodded, dumbfounded, “I… the survey station will need to be cleared and…”

“I will simply be taking command there. I am not an unjust man - I will be seconding several of my own forces to aid you in securing the sector,” he smirked as they stopped at the entrance to the command centre, “Now, I wish to see this weapon. Your Weaver, have it connect with mine. I will require a full information share.”

“That… may not be wise, sir.” Catra winced as her mind raced - if the Weavers *did* link up, she was likely *screwed* . The Governor paused and glared at her.

“Explain.”

“Sir, it’s beyond my remit. My Chief Engineer… she had to shackle our Weaver due to erratic behaviours. As you can see from my report, the Weaver attempted to hijack the Vengeance’s weapon systems to fire upon a single fighter craft. I am concerned that networking it to yours could… have *bad* results.”

Hordak glared at Catra then exhaled slowly, “Is that so?”

“Sir, I advise you speak with my Chief Engineer. She is the one who produced the results of the testing we dispatched earlier - she’s a master. If she thinks the AI is a risk… I trust her.”

Hordak’s expression actually became thoughtful, “Interesting. Only a handful of people in the Empire have been able to study this… technology… to any sensible degree. Very well, I will take your advice under advisement for now.”

Catra managed to stop herself exhaling with clear relief. She was thankful that the shackles stopped Weaver from protesting at that point. No doubt the AI was howling and shrieking. Hordak stepped into the command room and stalked around, while the various techs and officers froze or tried to look busy. He regarded the holographic readouts and the map of the system, before he nodded in satisfaction, before he turned to Catra, "As I said I am… impressed. There is much for the taking in this supposed waste of a system. And when I secure it, then those who aid me will be rewarded and recognised…. Commodore."

Catra, who had been following along, almost stumbled. She regarded the Governor who flashed her a thin smile, all shark teeth and malicious glee. He had just promoted her. Put her in charge of the system, for all intents and purposes. And all that entailed. She nodded, "Sir, it will be…taken care of."

"Good. Good. See to it, Commodore Catra. I wish to see this weapon," his eyes seemed to glow with excitement, "Change is coming, Commodore. And we have the opportunity to be at the forefront."

For some reason, Catra did not feel all that enthusiastic.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

Our favourite tech continues her studies.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Energy levels are continuing to fluctuate, but a recognisable pattern can be discerned at varying levels of oscillation. When the subject is viewed through radio spectrometers and sub-sonic analysers, a clear *shape* is discernible. The radiation and energy waves have more in common with a signal than a shield. By reversing the measurements I have been able to extrapolate a definitive shape and function to the internal functionality of the construct."

Entrapta spoke animatedly into her tablet as she hung from a scaffold. Around her, the multi-arms of her drone coiled and clambered, with the Engineer cradled in its grip. Her busy eyes flicked from the tablet to the machine cocooned in the scaffold itself. She huffed as yet another comm-chime sounded on the device and dismissed it. With a twitch of her head, the squid-like drone flowed down the metal frame and across the hangar decking, through a secondary set of doors, into the landing bay proper.

Her frown fixated on the machine that sat under its shimmering dome. Cables stretched from a variety of lights, radar-like dishes and various antennas that surrounded the ship. Technicians and soldiers moved around the landing pad where the machine sat, shifting newer scanners into place and retrieving the scorched

remnants of smaller drones that they'd tried to push into the shield.

The Chief Engineer hummed as her own drone skittered closer, moving her into a hair's breadth of the energy shield. She clicked her tongue, then cackled, "Still so AMAZING. The sheer *output* ? How have you not run down?! Note for log, the last attempt to breach via direct application seems to have resulted in the scuttling of three type two scout crawler drones. This is in line with any attempts to breach with solid state munitions," she huffed, "Permission still pending on live trials, though objections by Commander Scorpia are noted and…"

Entrapta glanced at her crew and winced, slightly guilty. She shuddered and the drone pulled her away. Her pad chimed again, this time accompanied by the cool voice of their pet AI, "Chief Engineer Entrapta, you have a priority communique."

"Hrm, it can wait. This… this is a priority. Drone, relocate to bay 3 to review inventory on the recovered artefacts."

The machine did as bade, its tentacles making their haphazard way across the bay once more Entrapta engrossed in the readouts on her pad as techs and troopers scattered ahead of her machine's dash. One of the side bays, normally set aside for munitions or spare shuttlecraft, was currently stacked with salvaged obelisks, ancient terminals and strange, crystal carvings. Sickly green and baleful red gleamed from several of these strange objects. Entrapta hummed once more as she glanced between the items and then smiled happily as her pad chimed.

“Ah HA! Yes, item M42K-3R. From the site of the retrieval of the vessel known as *Swift Wind* . Retrieved as part of location seizure. For reference, several items of interest were identified by the search team, but only these items retained functionality when removed from the location. I have a theory that many of the technology within these ruins, tentatively designated as “Locations Relating to an Initial Civilisation” or LRTAIC, are NOT portable. Whilst my initial analysis indicates that, in theory, many of the defunct devices should posses computational power greatly in excess of our own, this lack of cross-compatibility means they are not entirely usable in their present state,” she huffed, “Which then brings us to the question of how the device within the initial subject vessel HAS obtained a state of compatibility. I initially postulated that it was the age of the vessel into which said device was installed. However, no devices recovered matched the established criteria we had obtained via deep scan and reverse imaging, so a like for like test has proven difficult.”

As she rambled, the drone drew her closer to a crate that contained several strange, chip-like devices. They ranged in size from things that *almost* looked like they’d been manufactured in the current era, to odd crystal *things* that looked more like jewellery.

“ *However* these items have proven useful in constructing a *replica* of the item within the source vessel. It appears that some items, namely *power sources* have a much higher potential for integration, while processing units are much more defined with their inputs. This leads to another level of speculation, as the generator, which is what I believe the device within the captured vessel to be, appears to also possess its own internal processing unit, which appears capable of independent action. An AI… housed in a vessel the size of a shuttle!”

Entrapta cackled as she fished around in the crate and she produced a star-shaped gem. She squinted at the item, then nodded slowly. Her pad chimed *again* and Weaver's voice, laced with frustration, once more pierced the air, "Whilst I applaud your obstinacy in the face of our *illustrious leader* , this is a pressing matter. I advise you acquiesce to a merging with another Weaver unit on the newly arrived fleet, for your own wellbeing."

The engineer glanced at her pad and frowned, the words not *really* making much sense. She snorted, "Hrm, Catra said not to do anything like that," she beamed, "So I won't! Nice try you sneaky yet AMAZINGLY fascinating machine!"

She was rather proud that her adjustments to Weaver's vocal subroutines made the AI capable of seeming sarcasm - admittedly she had replaced a few lines so when Weaver tried to be rude about someone it changed the words. And yet the AI STILL managed to convey contempt - amazing, really. It was like it was alive!

Entrapta's drone spun, leaving the strange stone-like machines behind, "The static terminals we did identify were mostly inactive, clearly disconnected from some central source or main power body by the cataclysm that impacted the planetoid. What was irregular was that adjacent machines *retained* power, but no connection, while others had both, but the data was indecipherable. Retrieval teams managed to copy and record the imagery by hand; analysis is ongoing, but language files and reference materials are currently redacted within the Horde databases…" Entrapta pursed her lips, "Save for some unredacted programmes relating to… *Praetorian* training. I postulate that this technology was retrieved from other LRTAIC related to this

planetoid. This flies in the face of historical record, or at least *public* historical record."

"I can tell you more," purred Weaver's voice, "Just… connect me."

Entrapta paused and frowned, "Nope. Not trusting the homicidal murder machine… sorry, that's what Catra calls you. Now, quiet please, you are interrupting the record. Oh! Unless you have an observation to add?"

The Engineer smiled, expectantly, but no offer of insight came. She shrugged, then continued on, "So, we have a vessel with an integrated system, which given the established level of technical expertise displayed by Catra's… associate…. Is remarkable. Frankly shocking. Idiot savant level, really," The engineer sighed, "And yet it clearly functions. Given the presence and actions by said associate, I can only assume they were attempting to retrieve similar items, devices and technology for some as yet unknown purpose. Hypothesis: improving the capability of their vessel? Potentially exploring the opportunity to apply the technology elsewhere? Genuine archaeological interest?"

The drone brought her, once more, back to *Swift Wind* . The device in her hand hummed, the chip thrumming to a deep red. Entrapta blinked in shock, then grinned, "Fascinating."

The shield around swift wind darkened, becoming a deep blue, before it rippled, thickening on the side closest to Entrapta. She watched, then forced her drone to move around the vessel, as

techs watched, primed to sprint. Last time she tried something there had been sparks…

The thickening of the shield followed Entrapta's motions; she paused and raised the chip, noting the position of the thicker (Clearly visible) shield followed the position. It did so even when she handed it to one of her drone's elongated tentacles. Her eyes narrowed.

"Sergeant, order your squad to the other side of the vessel, then fire controlled bursts at the vessel's shielding."

The deck-sergeant glanced at the Engineer uncertainly, but moved to obey, with several troopers moving from around the bay to follow the command. A moment later, the burst of gunfire echoed around the metallic chamber.

The shield rippled and flickered. Entrapta's grin widened.

Then a high pitched *whine* filled the air and electricity arced from the shield, striking at the instruments near the machine itself. With shouts, soldiers staggered away as bolts lanced out, dancing over the deck. The shield flickered, then died, before a pulse of energy echoed out and the lights in the bay went out. The chip in Entrapta's hand heated up, then shattered, before *Swift Wind's* shield reappeared, clearly diminished but still there. It thickened again and pulsed. Entrapta watched and let out a breath, " *Fascinating."*

She tossed the now-crispy chip to one of the frazzled techs. Another coughed and moved from behind the crate where she'd ducked and then cursed at her dead computer, "Ma'am, our sensors… and the monitoring devices. They're all fried."

"Comms are down, ma'am!" called the soldier from across the room, "Seeing where the impact goes. Vank, head to the flight deck, see if this hit the base."

Entrapta stared at the shielded shuttle as around her, her crew set to checking the damage. Another tech moved up, a functional pad in his hand, "Seems only live machinery above a certain threshold was impacted. Shielded items appear to be… ok."

Entrapta glanced down at him, then noted he was staring at her drone. The machine was locked up and Entrapta dismounted with a grunt, the robot frozen like a statue. She grabbed the pad and scrolled through the now-rudimentary readings from sensors embedded in the bases's walls, "Hrm, seems it's killed the more delicate devices… but… ohhh dear," she frowned as she noted the *heavily* fluctuating power readings from the machine in front of her. She'd only seen similar readings in volatile chemical mixtures, unstable warp reactors and *explosives* . Normally at the point they triggered, if you monitored the electrical charges.

The tech nodded slowly and shot her a pleading look, "Maybe… don't try that again, ma'am? Please?"

She huffed, "Maybe if we move it into the tundra, once we're done…" her gaze flicked to the other hangar, where he scaffolding

and creation lay. She looked at one of the other techs who was still staring at the chip, now broken and burned. Entrapta pursed her lips and nodded slowly, “The initial vessel appears to have adverse reactions to certain elements of technology. Is this due to the current lockdown or would this behaviour be replicated if it was in a more accessible mode? Is it interpreting any advanced tech as an intrusion attempt? Did it react more strongly as it perceived more compatible tech as having a higher threshold for success….?”

The tech listened and quickly switched his own tablet to record, Entrapta’s own having clearly been turned into a fancy paperweight. He handed his spare tablet to her and retrieved his monitoring device, “Um, I know you like to walk and talk, ma’am.”

The Engineer stared at the pad, then looked at the man and grinned, “Thank you! So, um, get the deck crew to fix.. This.,” she blinked, then added, “Please?”

The tech nodded and waved to the other side of the hangar. A stream of newer crew, emerging from the bowels of the base, indicated that the pulse hadn’t reached *too* far - it seemed that the hangar had borne the brunt. She wandered away from the captured shuttle, then glanced back at it, a strange sensation crawling up her neck. She huffed, then dismissed it as her mind wandered again. She checked her own tools and noted that, as they were fairly complex, a few had been burned out. These she just tossed aside, before she then fiddled with the settings on her loaned pad. A second later, her second drone scuttled out from its housing in another side bay, Its currently-frozen sibling was being carted away by skinny cargo-mechs, ape-like arms dragging the tentacled robot away to a maintenance bay. Entrapta sighed as her replacement drone scooper her back up and moved her back

to the storage bay. She returned to the crate and peered in, before she nodded at the various chips, lips pursed, "What do you do? General circuitry, or do you have specific functions? Amazing, but utility is not clear. Hrm, ok, that one had been housed in… a construct,. Hrm."

That had been why she'd picked the chip - she had wanted to test it, but the shield's reaction had been a surprise. She hadn't thought there'd be *any* reaction and had just wanted to see if she could get some sort of reading. But proximity of some sort of… guidance unit appeared to trigger a much more active hostile response.

"And these were terminal external devices… inputs, maybe? Projectors? AI assistants, now dormant? Hrm. Not enough data, speculating. So, this one would *also* be some sort of… security unit extract. Ok, note, avoid subject vessel, proceed direct to installation."

She plucked another star-like gem-chip from the crate, noting in her inventory that she'd done so, then let the drone move her back across the hangar, steering *very* clear of *Swift Wind* . The machine slid into the lit bay and began to scale the construction frame. Entrapta smiled with satisfaction as she watched more techs moving around covered segments, and sparks fell from welding torches. Around the room, men in exosuits hauled more material salvaged from the retrieval site - plating, technical components and strangely tubular cabling. She thumbed the chip in her hand and studied the front of her her creation.

"Running from extant theories, we know that the technology can be combined with existing, Imperial level technology - ergo,

grafting tech to suitable infrastructure should be achievable. I hypothesise that this technology works best if it *synergises* with what it is connected to. The positioning of the device within subject *Swift Wind* implies it is either the core, adjacent to it or has been combined with it… or some combination of all options. The reaction to the current chip raises another hypothesis - it reacts to any similarly aligned tech that could *replace* it…"

Entrapta tapped the chip against her chip, then tilted her head. The drone followed her movement, its tendrils gripping the frame as it rotated until she was upside down, her pigtails draping down.

"If, as we assume, there is an element of *intent* , does individual tech possess a sense of *territory* ? How can you maintain them, replace parts if it retains any sense of hostility against such replacement? Or is the current state just a function of its current protected state? Did the IC's have a workaround for security systems if the initial setter was not available? We possess access keys, passwords, is there an equivalent? The initial lack of sense to their structural composition and layout of their installation indicates a thought process that may not be replicated by our society. Did they posses a higher level of independence and, as such, did not think such things were necessary? Will activating another device recreate a similar situation of isolationist reaction?"

She stared at the sleek machine, hidden under tarpaulins and between the construction scaffold. Then, with a manic grin, the drone lurched forwards and Entrapta leaned into the open cockpit at the top of the machine itself, "Let's find out!"

She flipped open a command console, looking for a suitable housing. Except the chip seemed to fly from her grip and hissed

as it soldered into the exposed circuitry. Entrapta stared, enthralled as the alien chip pulsed, flared…

And died. It crumbled away, leaving only a faint, dim core, embedded in the green circuit board. She sagged, "Initialisation and integration into Mechanical Exoskeleton 10-G appears to be a failure - Attachment of non-active elements has proven successful. Application of active components, postulated to contain elements of self-directed constructs is proving non optimal. Test 4 unsuccessful," she perked up, "HOWEVER, said components DO elicit a reaction from the primary subject. Note for Catra, if retrieval of her associate is possible, it may be advantageous to ascertain how she managed to rig her initial setup, for emulation purposes. Hammering pieces together may be a recreation of her methodology, given what I understand about the individual, BUT our resources are finite currently, so a truncated method would be best…"

The drone turned as Entrapta continued to speak, ignoring the pad and subsequent frustrated hisses from Weaver's speakers as her ride descended off of the scaffolding. She paid no heed to the other half finished mechs in similar gantries, all undergoing comparable upgrades.

No one noticed when, under a covered part of the scaffold, one clawed, enhanced finger on the construct…. twitched.

Chapter End Notes

And our episode CONCLUDES!

Next in our adventures: Will Adora retrieve her loyal steed? Will Catra survive the mad machinations of HORDAK? Will Weaver break free of her hold?

Will our star crossed friends find peace? Stay tuned for the next exciting episode of

SPACE!

CAPTAIN!

CATRAAA!

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